IISER Kolkata · iGEM 2026 · FINS project
In collaboration with Ek Pehal

Why did schooling stop?

A field survey of women in Ghoragacha and Mohanpur

Women's own accounts of schooling, marriage, work and what would help, with comparisons across age groups and villages

Villages	Ghoragacha and Mohanpur, near the IISER Kolkata campus. They are slum areas.
Women approached	103 (91 agreed to be recorded; 12 declined)
Language	Bengali (one interview taken in Hindi)
Prepared by	Inclusivity team, iGEM IISER Kolkata 2026 in collaboration with EkPehal
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Status	First phase of the survey completed (report of the first phase is attached)

Summary

Over the course of our project for the year 2026, student volunteers from IISER Kolkata (from the Inclusivity Team and EkPehal) spoke with women in two villages (slum dwellings), Ghoragacha and Mohanpur, about their own schooling and about what would help girls study today. We approached **103 women**. **91 agreed** to have their answers recorded (88%), and **12 declined**. One respondent was under 18 and is left out of the analysis, so the findings below describe **90 women, aged 18 to 65**. The women were those available when we visited; this is not a random sample, and the results describe the women we spoke with, not all women in the two villages.

What the women told us

- **One in four never went to school.** 22 of 89 women (25%; 95% interval 17–35%) never attended. Among women under 30 it was 1 of 17; among women 50 and over it was 11 of 23.
- **Schooling has risen sharply across generations.** Reaching class 9 or beyond was reported by 13 of 17 women under 30 and 15 of 29 aged 30–39, but by only 3 of 38 aged 40 and over.
- **Marriage and cost were the two most common reasons.** Marriage was mentioned by 51 of 86 women (59%) and cost or poverty by 47 (55%). Among the 47 who named a biggest reason, cost (22) and marriage (17) led.

- **Housework and care duties** were mentioned by 30 women (35%), and ***a family view that girls did not need much schooling*** by 26 (30%). Distance or the lack of a nearby school was mentioned by 11 (13%).
- **The decision usually was not hers.** Of 55 women who said who decided she would stop, 21 named parents, 16 in-laws or husband, 10 herself, and 8 said nobody decided, it just happened.
- **What would have helped:** family support (38 of 51), help with fees, books or a scholarship (29), less housework (16), a school nearby or transport (10), and someone to guide her (9).
- **Many still want to learn.** 43 of 77 (56%) said yes or maybe to studying or learning something now. Most named a practical skill such as sewing or computers. Time, money, confidence and age were the barriers named.
- **For girls today,** the women who answered most often wanted girls to study "as far as she wants" (12 of 28), and named fees, books or scholarships as the main help (16 of 23).
- **Younger women have studied much further.** The typical woman in her 20s reached class 9 or 10; in her 40s, class 5; in her 60s, none. The reasons also shift: cost for older women, marriage for younger ones. Women of every age mostly wanted girls to study far (22 of 27).
- **The two villages look alike on schooling and interest in learning:** ever attended school (77% in Ghoragacha, 74% in Mohanpur), reached class 9 or above (40% and 33%), wants to learn now (50% and 60%). None of these differences is larger than chance would produce with samples this size.

Disclaimer:
(1) These are the accounts of women who were available and willing; women who declined, or were not at home, may differ
(2) Reasons are what women said, and several reasons usually act together; they are not proof of cause
(3) Two different record-keeping styles were used. For Ghoragacha, entries were recorded in a notebook and entered in the google form later. For Mohanpur, the google form was filled by the volunteers while the interview was ongoing.
(4) Not all women agreed to answer all questions. We didn't force the women who hesitated to answer. Every figure shows its own number of women (n).

1. Why we did this survey

This year, the iGEM Team of IISER Kolkata (FINS) decided to look at the most common barriers in our locality to attempt to understand who is missing from science and education, and why. Our own campus has fewer women than men, and we wanted to understand what happens much earlier: in the villages around us, why do women stop studying? We hoped the answers would help us, local organisations and the institute's administration think about practical support for girls now, rather than guess.

We asked women about their own schooling because they know it best. We asked what stopped them, who decided, what would have made a difference, and what they would like for girls in their care today. We did not ask for names, and we did not ask about caste, religion or income. No personal identifying information was collected. All the data presented here is anonymised.

This report is for local NGOs, Ek Pehal, and the institute's administration. It is meant to be read by non-specialists. Each chart has a plain-language caption, and the technical detail is in the appendices.

2. Who we spoke to, and how

2.1 Where and how women were approached

- **Ghoragacha.** We visited 50 of the roughly 200 households. In each household we spoke with the woman who was available. 45 agreed to have her answers recorded and 5 declined. The entries were recorded in a notebook and entered in the google form later.
- **Mohanpur.** Interviewers walked along the highway for 1.8 km in each direction from the school where our earlier outreach sessions were held (3.6 km in total) and spoke with women who were available. 46 agreed to be recorded and 7 declined. The google form was filled by the volunteers while the interview was going on.
- **Selection.** We spoke with whoever was available at the time, so women who were out at work or school, and women who were reluctant to talk to strangers, are less likely to be included. This is called a convenience sample. We make no claim that it represents all women in either village.

2.2 Numbers

	Approached	Agreed to be recorded	Declined	Agreed (%)
Ghoragacha	50	45	5	90%
Mohanpur	53	46	7	87%
Both villages	103	91	12	88%

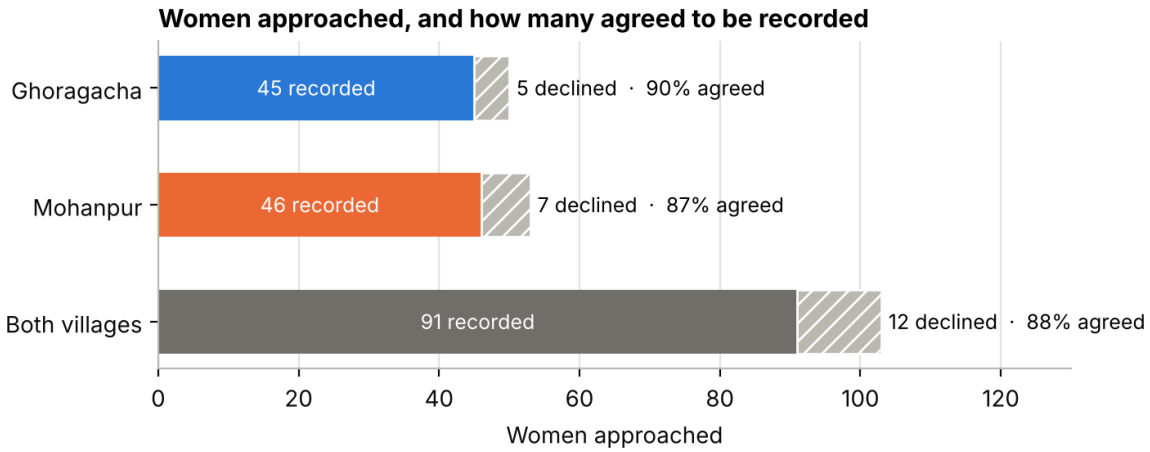


Figure 1. Women approached and how many agreed to be recorded. The 12 women who declined are included in the 103 approached; none of their answers were recorded.

Of the 91 women recorded, one was under 18 (the survey was designed for adults). Her answers are not used in any chart or figure in this report. The analysis therefore covers **90 women**. Including her would not change any finding (the share who never attended school is 22 of 89 with her excluded, and 22 of 90 with her included).

Two small groups of respondents live in the same household (three in one, two in another). Their answers are not fully independent of each other. With 90 women, this has a very small effect on the results.

2.3 The interview

Interviews were in Bengali (except one, which was in Hindi) and took about 20 minutes. Interviewers read a short introduction, asked for spoken consent, and recorded a serial number and age only, not a name. The questionnaire covered: age, schooling, reading and writing, current work, children; for women who stopped or never started, the reasons in her own words; who decided; marriage at the time; distance to school; brothers' and sisters' schooling; what would have helped; whether she would like to study now and what would make it hard; mobile phone use; girls in her care and what would help them; and whether she knows a woman who studied further and works, amongst other questions. The google form used by the interviewers is attached in the wiki.

2.4 What we did with the answers

Answers were typed into a form by the interviewer, then grouped (coded) by our team into categories, for example "Marriage" or "Cost / poverty". A woman could give more than one reason, so percentages for reasons add to more than 100%. Wherever a chart says n, that is the number of women who answered that question; it changes between charts because not every question was answered by every woman. Intervals quoted in the text are 95% Wilson confidence intervals, a standard way to show how much a percentage could shift with a sample this size.

3. The women we spoke with

The women ranged from 18 to 65 years (median 36, middle half 30–50; age was recorded for 86 of 90). The two villages had almost the same age profile (median 36 in Ghoragacha and 36 in Mohanpur).

Note: *Few of the women could not recall their age, some others were confused. Out of them, those women whose family members were able to give a rough age bracket, have been considered in the data. Others who couldn't confirm their age at all have been excluded in the following graph. Their responses, however, have been considered.*

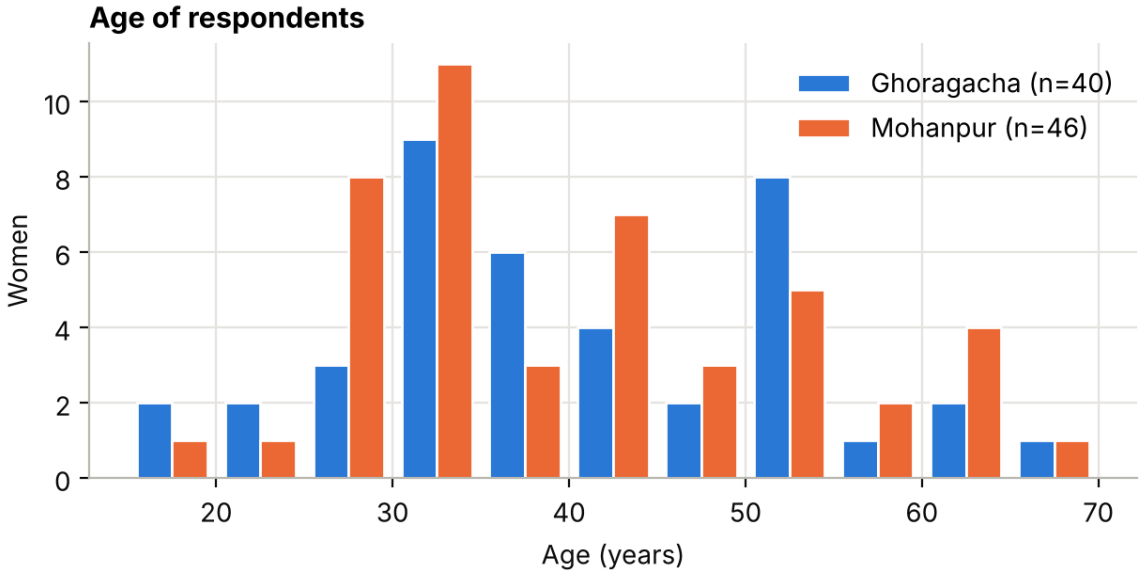


Figure 2. Age of the women recorded, by village (5-year bands).

3.1 Schooling

Of 89 women with a recorded level, 22 (25%) never attended school, 33 (37%) left at primary or upper primary level (classes 1–8), 18 (20%) left at class 9 or 10, and 14 (16%) reached class 11 or college. For 2 women who had attended, the class was not recorded because they could only attend school for a few days before they were asked to leave. The class they had been admitted to was pre-primary (PP), which has not been considered here.

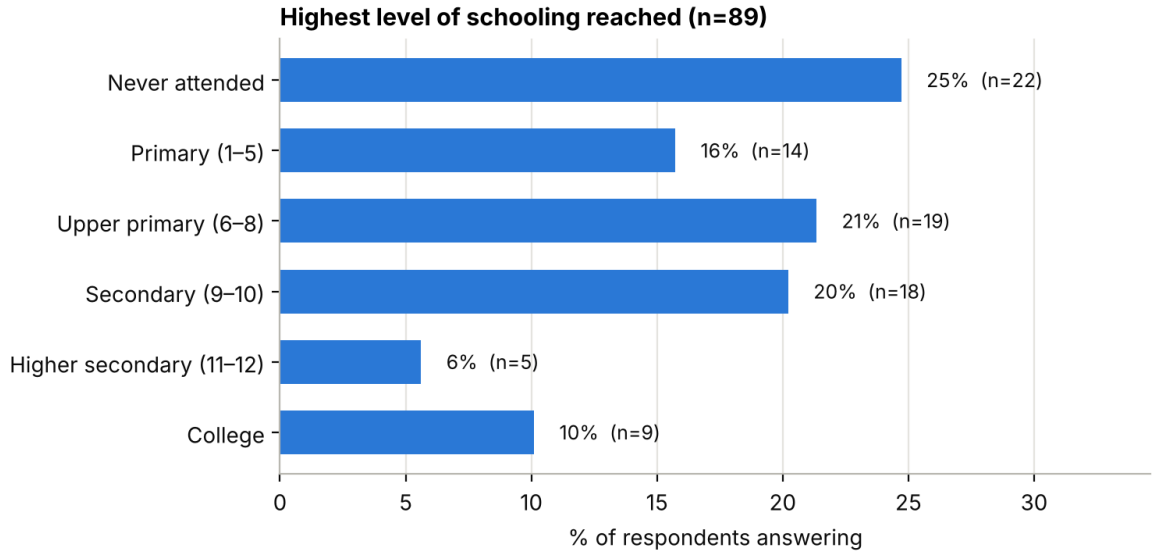


Figure 3. Highest level of schooling reached. "College" includes women who said they had begun or finished a degree.

The pattern in Ghoragacha and Mohanpur was similar (next chart). Differences between the villages at each level are small and well within what chance would give with groups of this size.

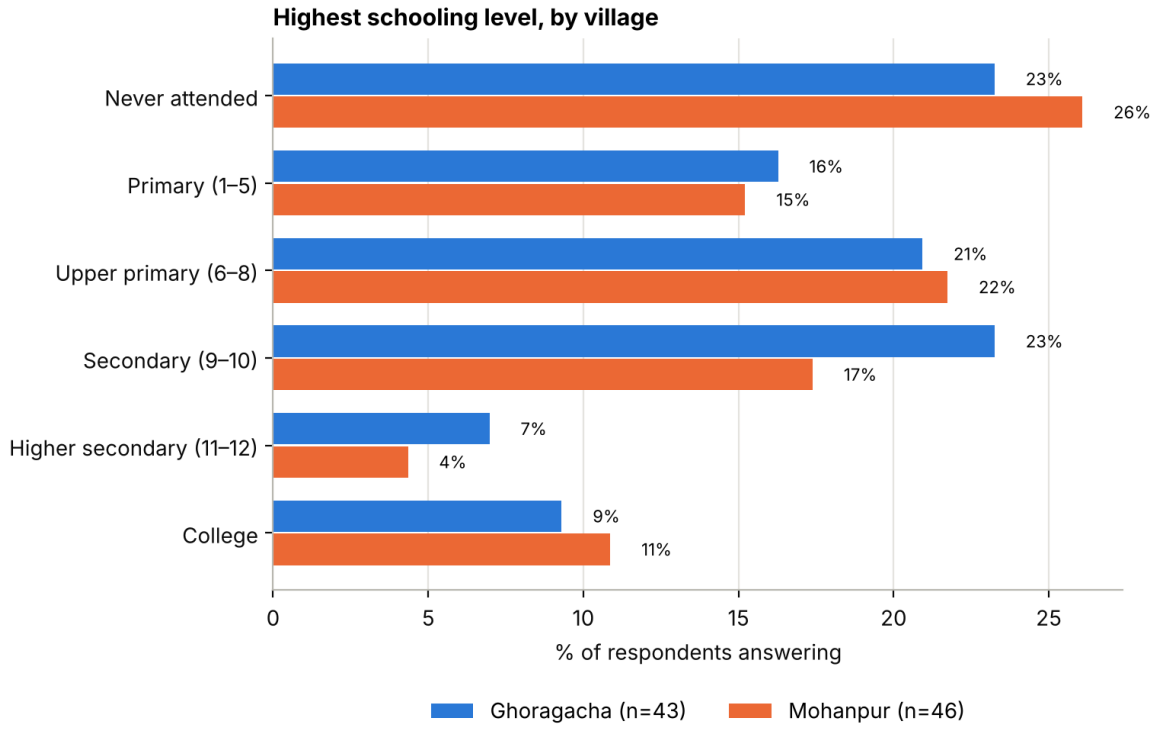


Figure 4. Highest schooling level, by village.

3.2 Reading and writing

Reading and writing was recorded for 53 women, nearly all from Mohanpur. 35 (66%) said they could do both, 5 read only, 2 could sign their name only, and 11 (21%) could do neither. This is the woman's own account; we did not test reading.

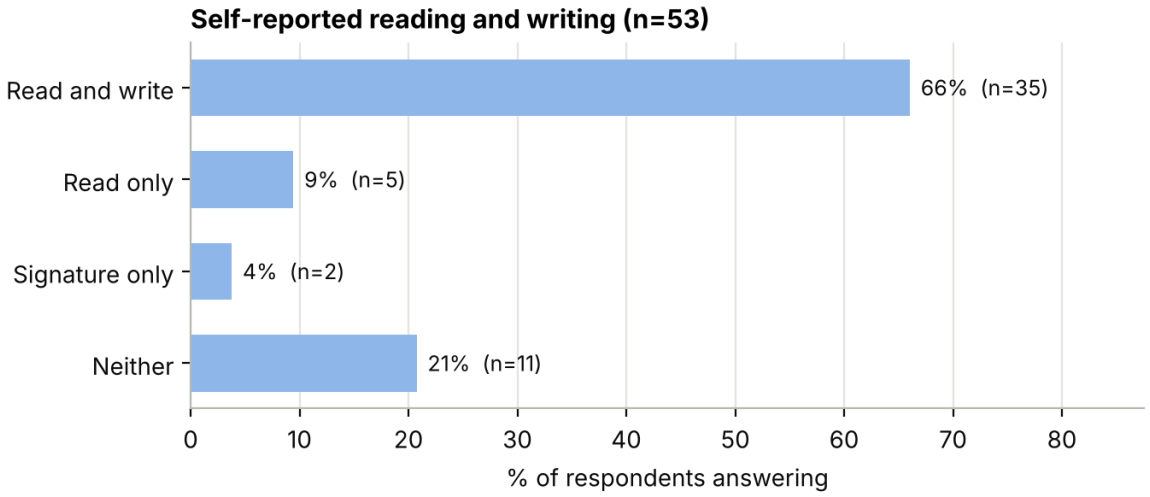


Figure 5. Self-reported reading and writing (mostly from Mohanpur).

3.3 Work and children

Work was recorded for 55 women. 37 (67%) described their main work as running the household. The rest did farm or family work (6), paid labour or domestic help (6), their own work or small business such as sewing or a tea shop (5), or a salaried post (1). Of 81 women where children were recorded, 76 had children and 5 did not.

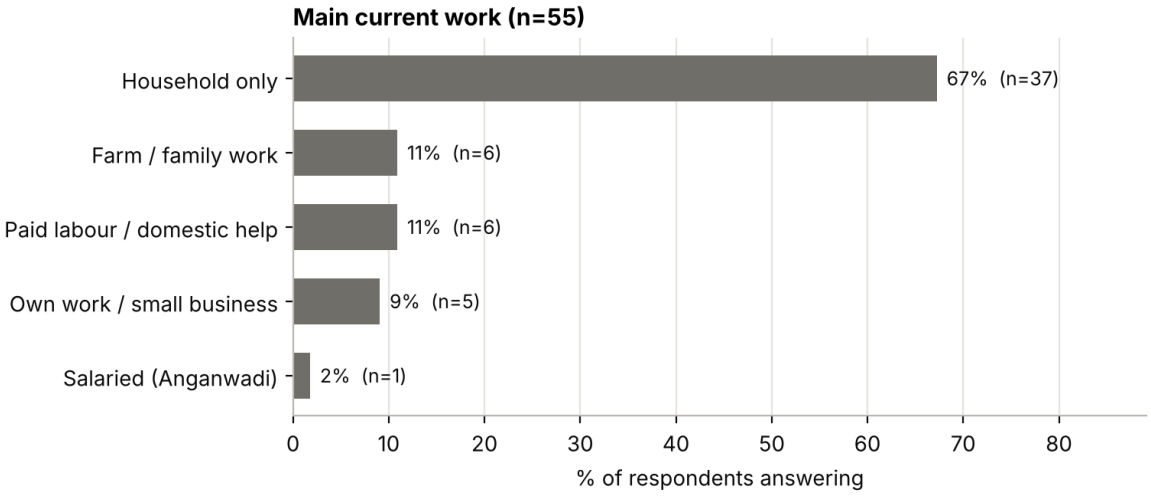


Figure 6. Main current work (mostly from Mohanpur). "Household only" means housework and caring without paid or farm work.

4. Schooling across generations

Older women in our sample went to school much less than younger women. This is the clearest pattern in the survey. The numbers inside the bars are percentages.

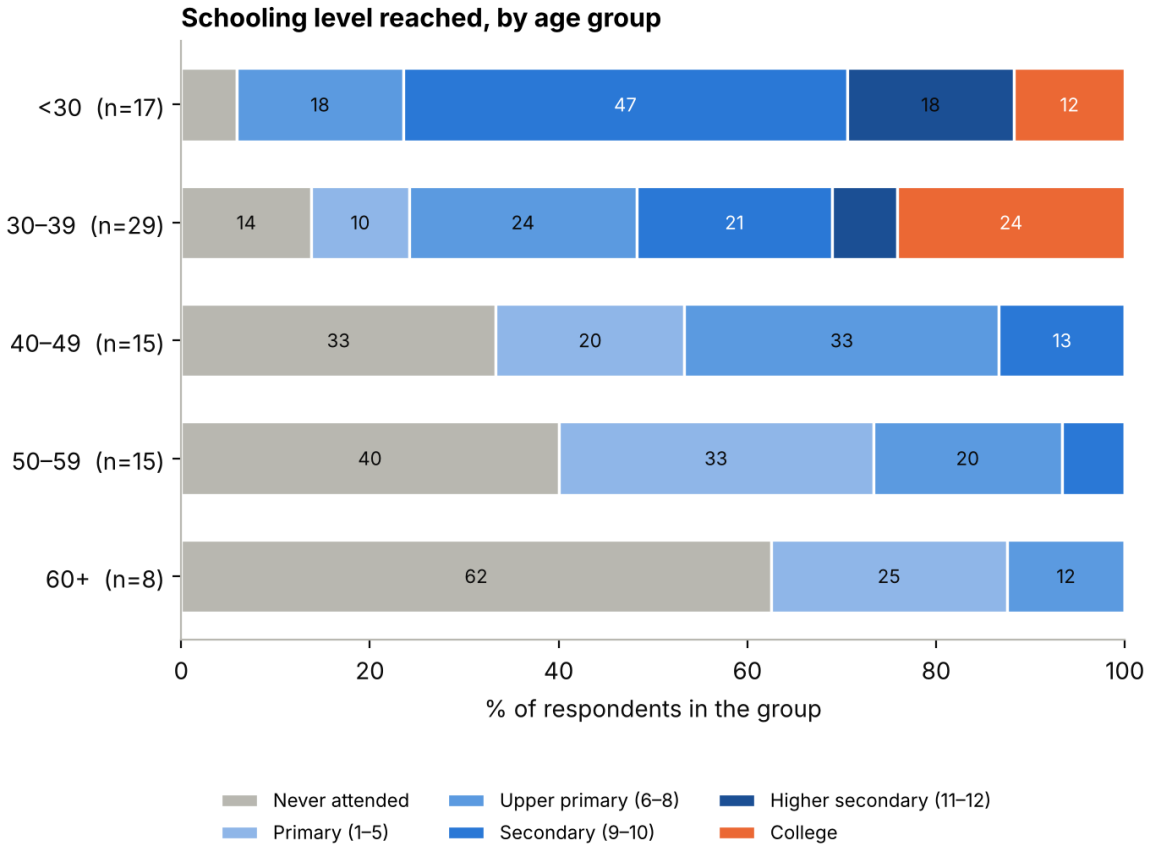


Figure 7. Highest schooling level, by age group. Numbers inside the bars are percentages. Groups are small (8 to 29 women), so treat each bar as indicative.

Age group	Women (n)	Never attended	Reached class 9 or above
<30	17	1 (6%)	13 (76%)
30–39	29	4 (14%)	15 (52%)
40–49	15	5 (33%)	2 (13%)
50–59	15	6 (40%)	1 (7%)
60+	8	5 (62%)	0 (0%)

Across all 84 women with a recorded age and schooling level, older age goes with fewer classes completed (rank correlation ρ = -0.57; this is a strong relationship). Each dot below is one woman.

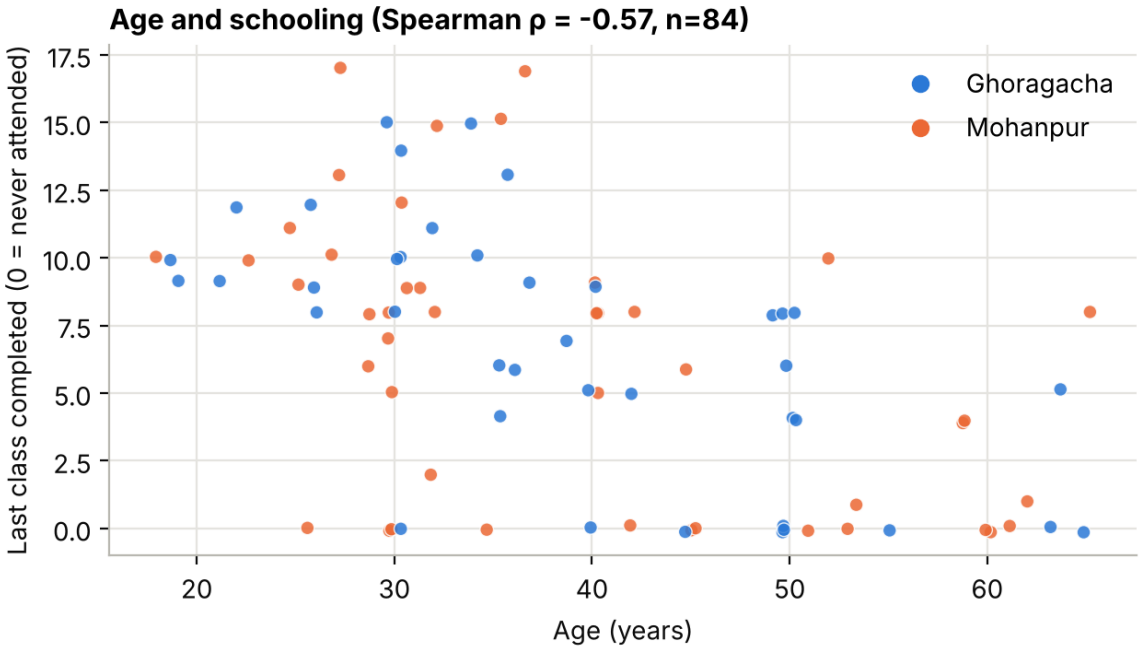


Figure 8. Age and last class completed. Points are jittered slightly so they do not overlap.

> **Note:**
> Older and younger women differ in schooling because the world they grew up in differed: school access, costs, and what families expected of girls. It does not show that any one woman's own choices differed. Also, women recall their schooling from many years ago, and some older women may not remember class exactly.

5. Why schooling stopped, or never began

86 of the 90 women have at least one reason recorded, in her own words as written down by the interviewer. Four entries have none: one woman said she does not remember, one had reached graduation, and two have nothing recorded. For women in the interviews, interviewers asked for her own reasons first and recorded it, thereafter certain prompts were supplied (only in the cases where the women seemed either hesitant or unable to answer) off a list and asked if each applied. A woman could give several reasons.

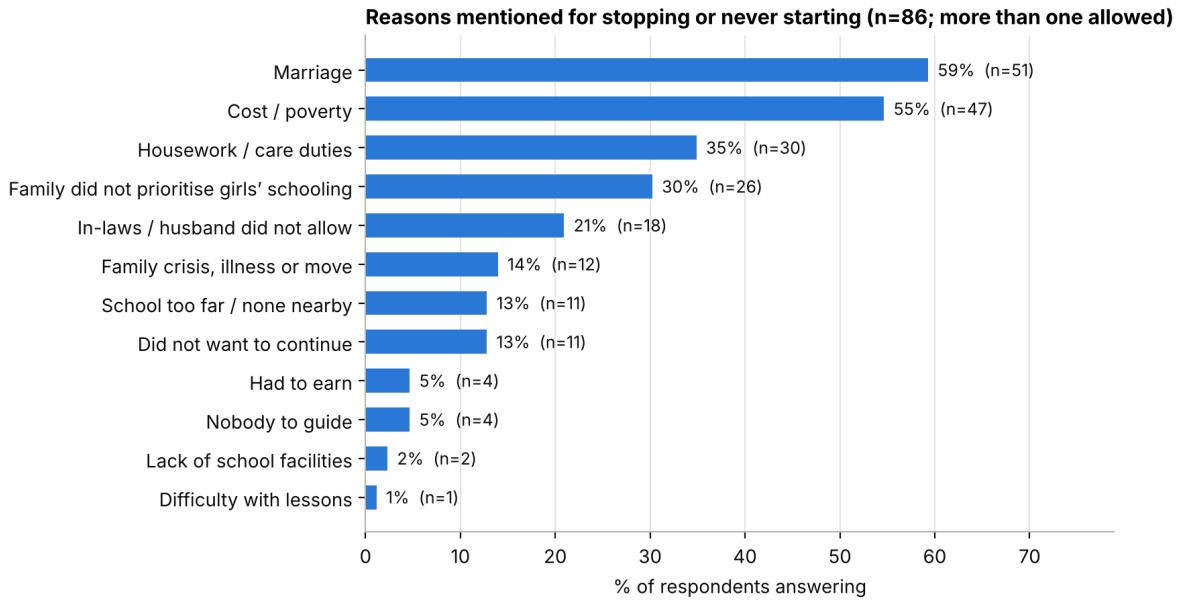


Figure 9. Reasons mentioned for stopping or never starting school (more than one allowed). (The grouping has been done by the interviewers using a common template to record answers)

Reason	Women	% of 86	95% interval
Marriage	51	59%	49–69%
Cost / poverty	47	55%	44–65%
Housework / care duties	30	35%	26–45%
Family did not prioritise girls' schooling	26	30%	22–41%
In-laws / husband did not allow	18	21%	14–31%
Family crisis, illness or move	12	14%	8–23%
School too far / none nearby	11	13%	7–22%
Did not want to continue	11	13%	7–22%
Had to earn	4	5%	2–11%
Nobody to guide	4	5%	2–11%
Lack of school facilities	2	2%	1–8%
Difficulty with lessons	1	1%	0–6%

Where a woman was asked which reason was the biggest, she could name more than one. **The two reasons named most often were cost and marriage.**

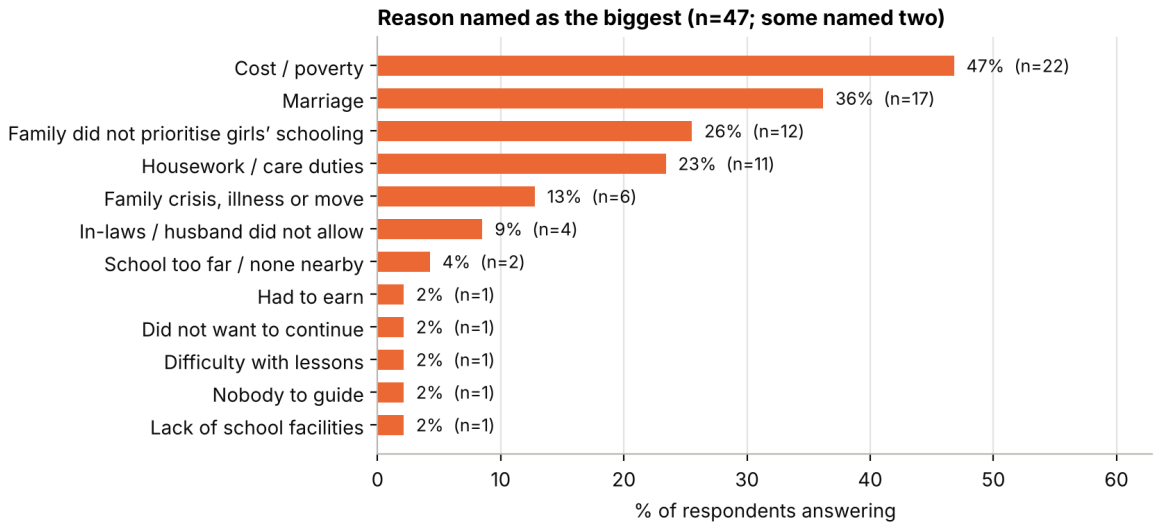


Figure 10. The reason named as the biggest (47 women answered; some named two, so counts add to more than 47).

5.1 Cost and marriage: two reasons, two kinds of story

Women who **never attended** and women who **attended and then stopped** described different paths. Among those who never attended (21 women), cost or poverty was the reason mentioned most often (16 of 21, 76%); marriage was mentioned by 4 (19%). Among those who attended and then stopped (65 women), marriage was mentioned by 47 (72%) and cost by 31 (48%), and 18 (28%) said in-laws or husband did not agree to continued study, which no woman who never attended said.

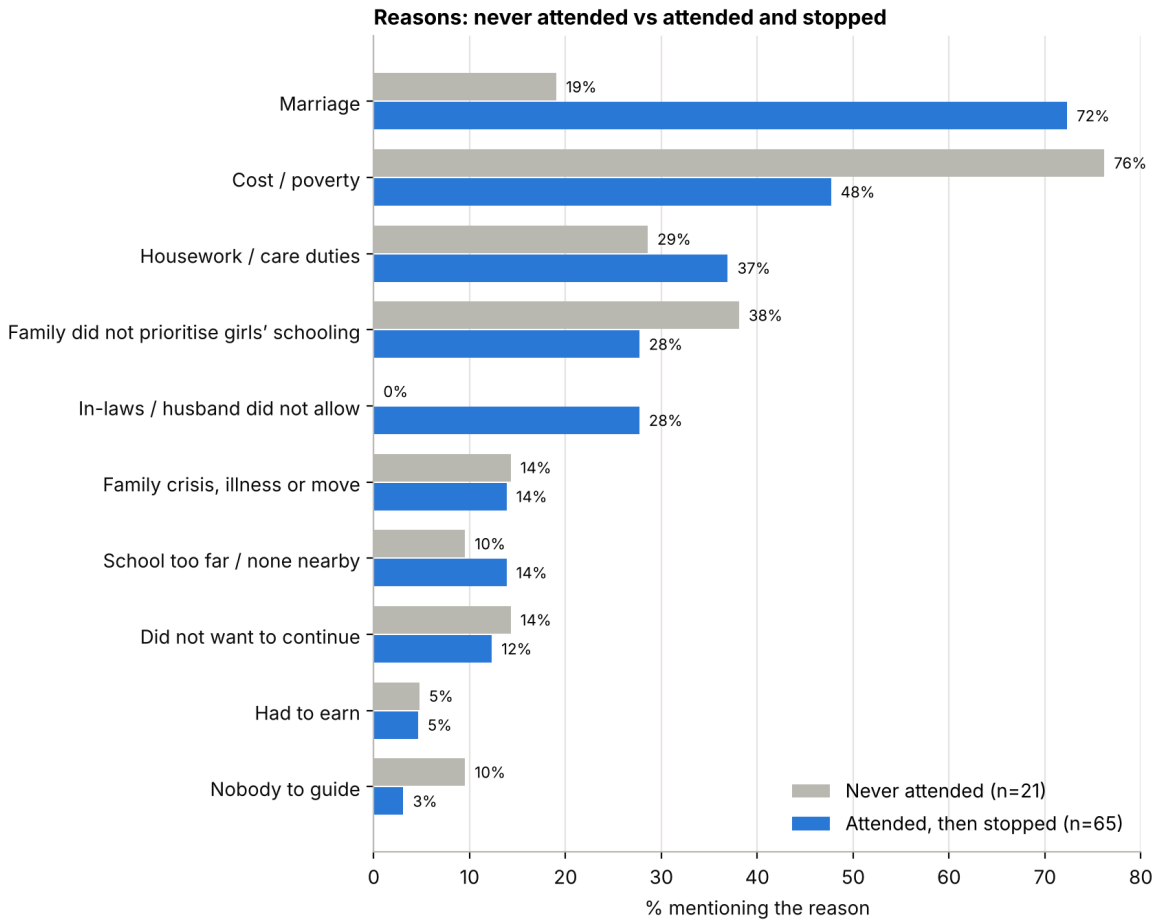


Figure 11. Reasons mentioned, by whether the woman never attended or attended and then stopped.

In plain terms: for many women the question was whether a girl would be sent to school at all, and money and family priorities decided that. For others, school was going well until marriage, and then marriage, in-laws and household duties ended it.

5.2 Reasons across age groups

Marriage was the most-mentioned reason among women under 40, and cost was the most-mentioned among women 40 and over. This fits the pattern of schooling in Section 4: for older women, school was often out of reach for reasons of money; for younger women, more of whom reached secondary school, marriage became the point at which it stopped. The groups are small, so these are indications rather than firm findings.

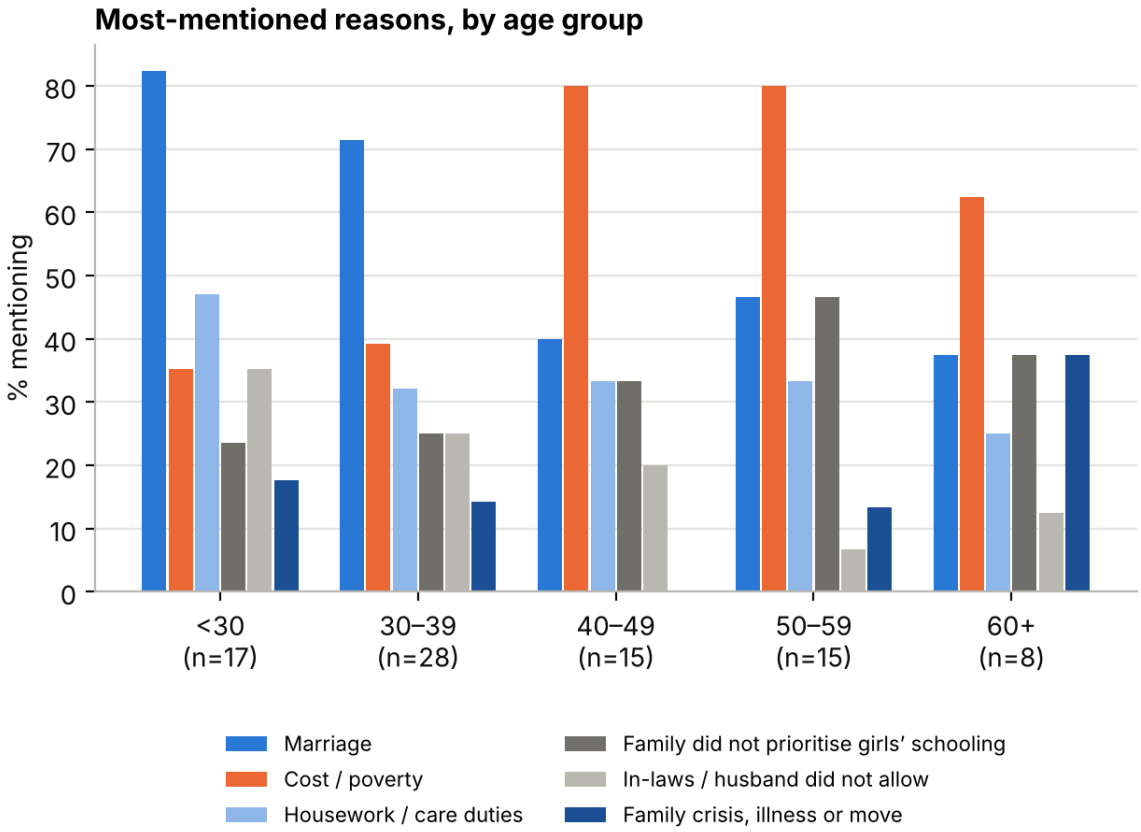


Figure 12. The six most-mentioned reasons, by age group.

5.3 Who decided?

Of 55 women who answered, 21 (38%) said parents decided she would stop, 16 (29%) said in-laws or husband, 10 (18%) said she decided herself, and 8 (15%) said nobody decided, it just happened. "Herself" should not be read as free choice; some women who said this also described pressure from family.

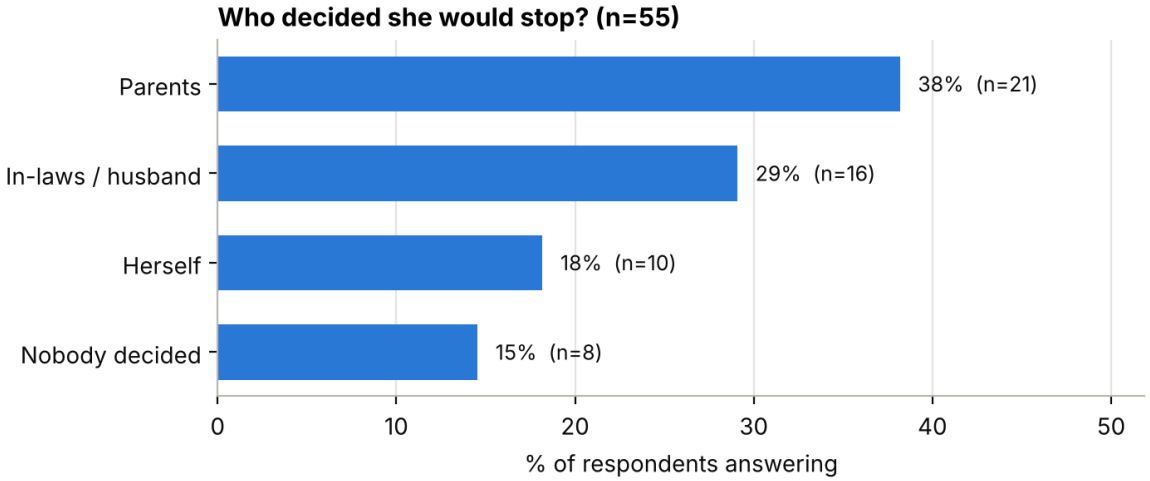


Figure 13. Who decided that she would stop (Mohanpur and a few Ghoragacha women).

The answer depends on whether she was married or engaged at the time. Among the 23 women who were, in-laws or husband were named by 9 and parents by 2. Among the 25 who were not, 18 named parents.

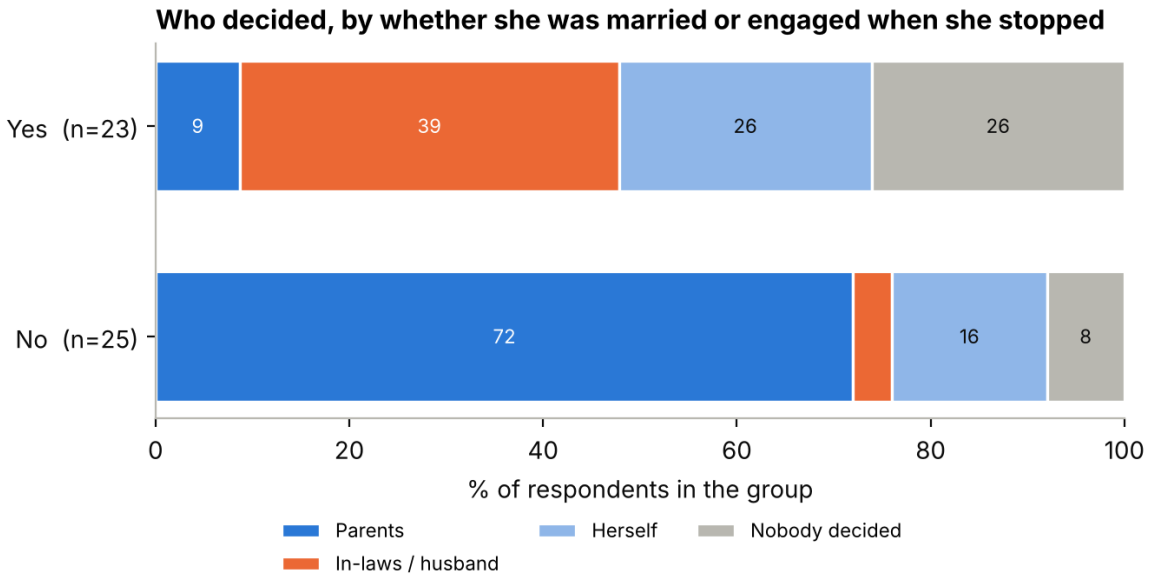


Figure 14. Who decided, by whether she was married or engaged when she stopped. Numbers inside bars are percentages.

5.4 Distance and brothers

Distance to the school she would have attended was recorded for 45 women. 27 (60%) said the school was within 3 km on foot, 7 said it was more than 3 km, 6 said they needed a cycle or vehicle, and 5 said there was no school nearby. So for most women who answered, a school was within reach; distance was part of the story for some, not for most.

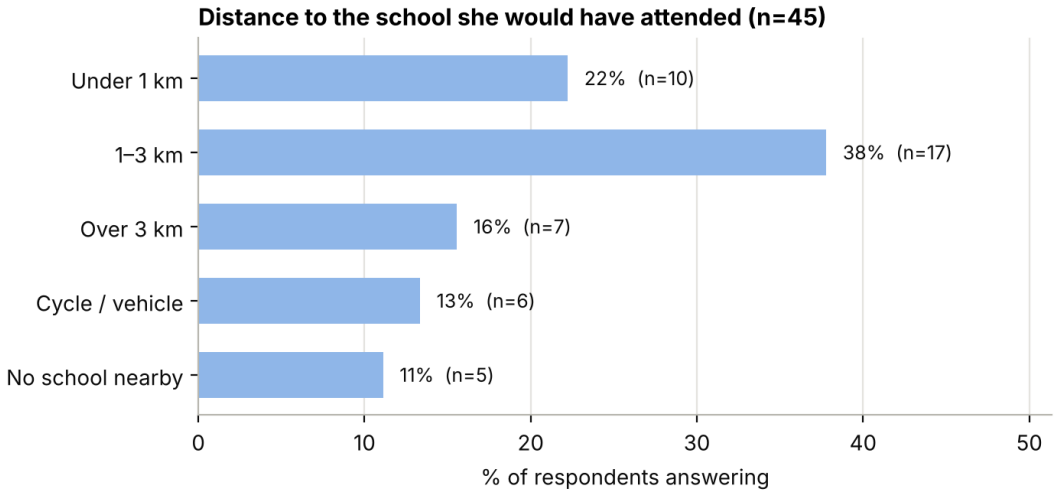


Figure 15. Distance to the school she would have attended.

Where women reported on their brothers' schooling compared with their own (n=41 who gave an answer we could classify), 24 (59%) said a brother studied further than they did, and 17 said brothers studied about the same or less. Several women commented, in their own words, that sons were given priority or that only the funds for one boy's education were available.

6. What would have made a difference

We asked what would have made it possible to continue, (n=51). Family support was named by 38 women (74%), help with fees, books or a scholarship by 29 (57%), less work at home by 16 (31%), a school nearby or safe transport by 10 (20%), and someone to guide her by 9 (18%).

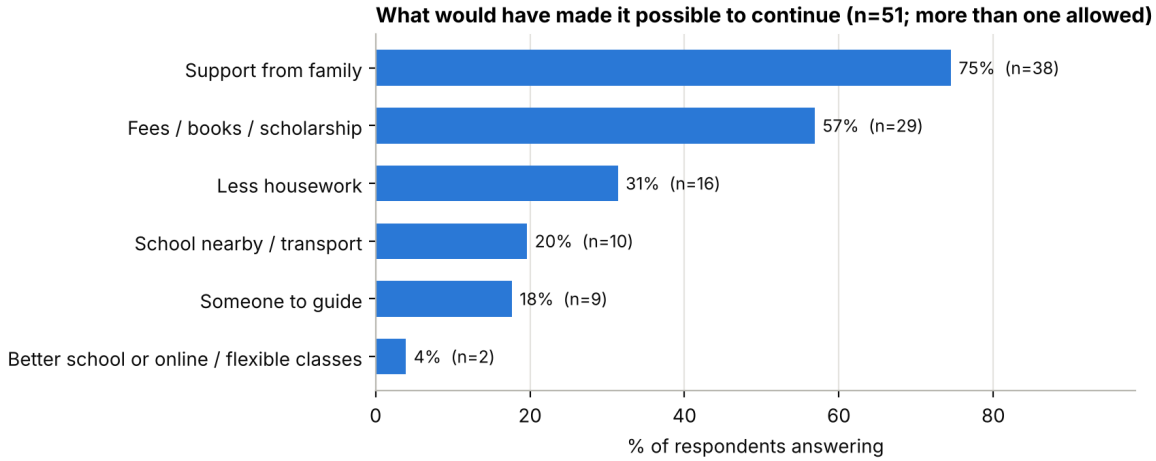


Figure 16. What would have made it possible to continue (more than one allowed; Mohanpur and some Ghoragacha women).

Family support was named by three in four women who answered this question. This matters for programme design: money alone would not have changed things for many of the women we spoke with.

7. Learning now

7.1 Do women want to study or learn?

30 of 77 women (39%) said yes and 13 (17%) said maybe to studying or learning something now; 34 (44%) said no. Some women who said no added that they had wanted to earlier but did not now.

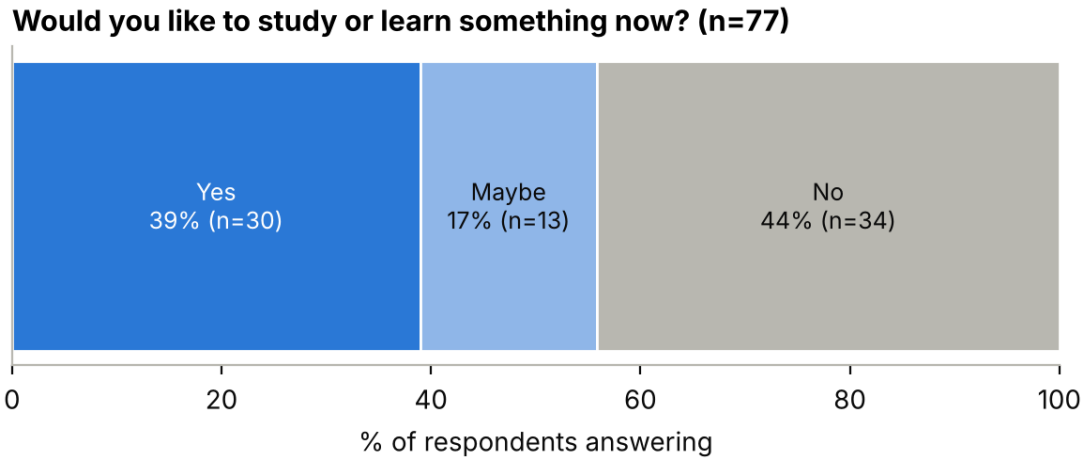


Figure 17. Would you like to study or learn something now?

Interest was present in every age group: 5 of 12 under 30, 16 of 24 aged 30–39, 9 of 16 aged 40–49, 6 of 15 aged 50–59 and 5 of 7 aged 60 and above said yes or maybe. Group sizes are small, so we do not read a trend into the differences.

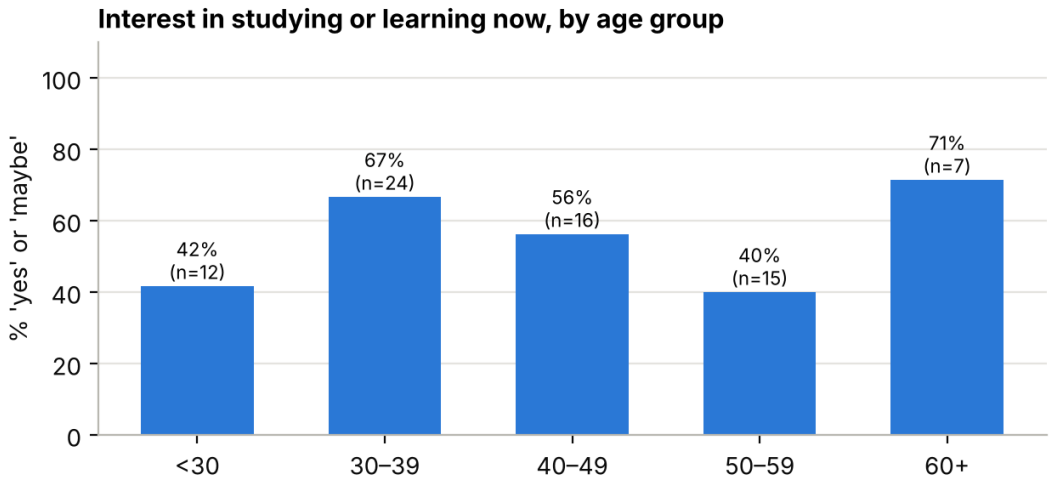


Figure 18. Share saying yes or maybe, by age group.

Women who named something they would like to learn (n=29) mostly named a practical skill such as sewing or computers (19), followed by basic reading and writing (6) and a school certificate through open school (4). All 6 women who said that they would like to learn basic reading and writing, said that learning to sign their own name was the one thing they wanted to learn. Many women who said that they don't want to learn anything anymore, commented that just learning to sign their names on bank documents would be enough.

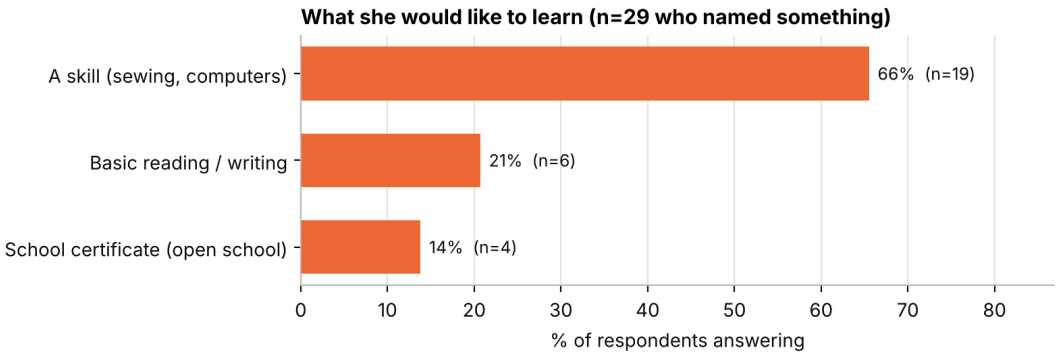


Figure 19. What she would like to learn.

7.2 What would make it hard

Time was the most common barrier (25 of 47, 53%), followed by money (13), confidence (12), family, children or housework (11) and age (9). Five women said nothing would make it hard. "Confidence" and "age" were raised by some women and are worth noting: they are not about fees or distance.

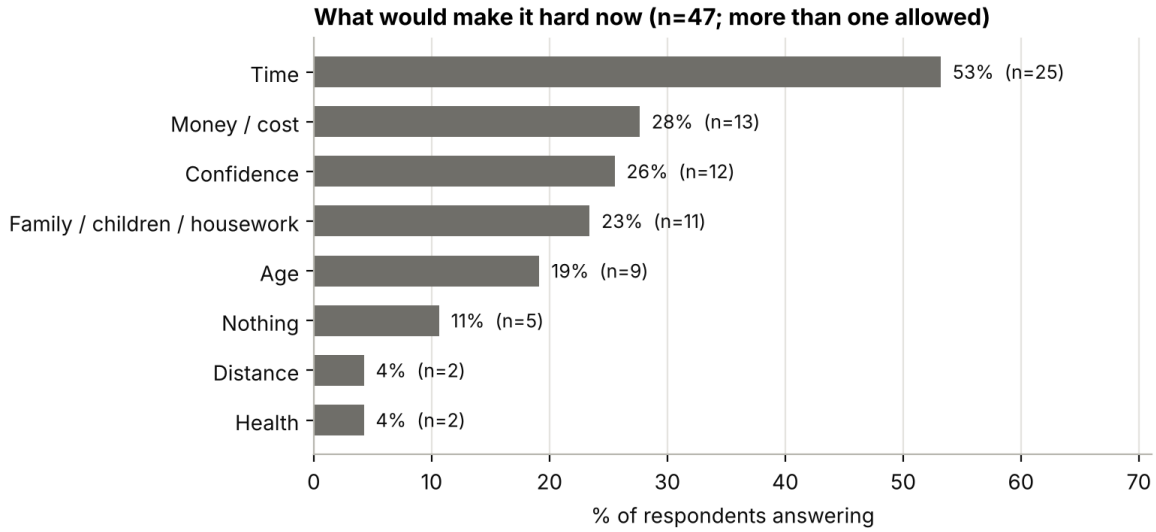


Figure 20. What would make it hard to study or learn now (more than one allowed).

7.3 Mobile phones

Phone use was recorded for 51 women (almost all from Mohanpur): 22 (43%) had their own smartphone, 14 had a basic phone, 4 shared a phone with family and 11 (22%) did not use a phone. Younger women were more likely to have a smartphone (see chart). This is relevant to any plan to offer learning by phone or video.

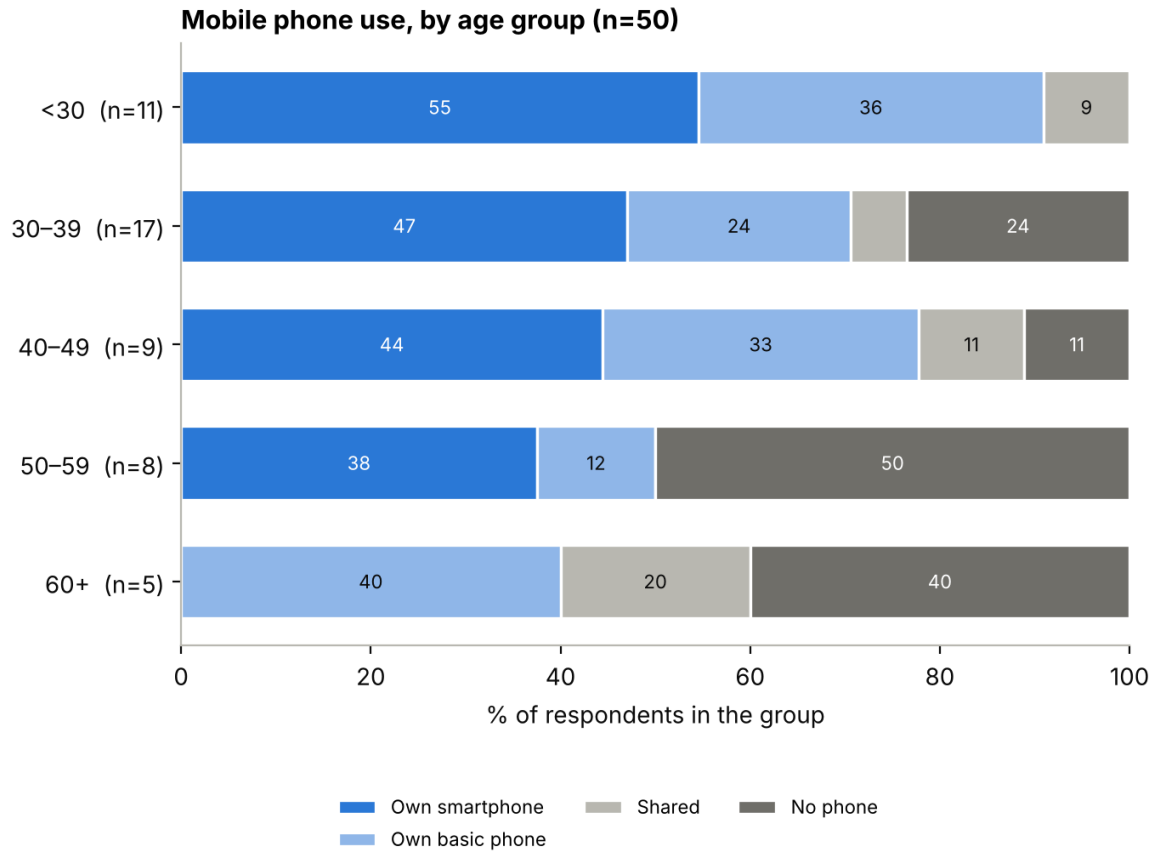


Figure 21. Mobile phone use, by age group (mostly Mohanpur).

7.4 Role models

Of 39 women asked whether they know a woman who studied further and works (for example a teacher, nurse or doctor), 13 (33%) knew one personally, 10 had heard of one, 6 were not sure and 10 (26%) did not know any.

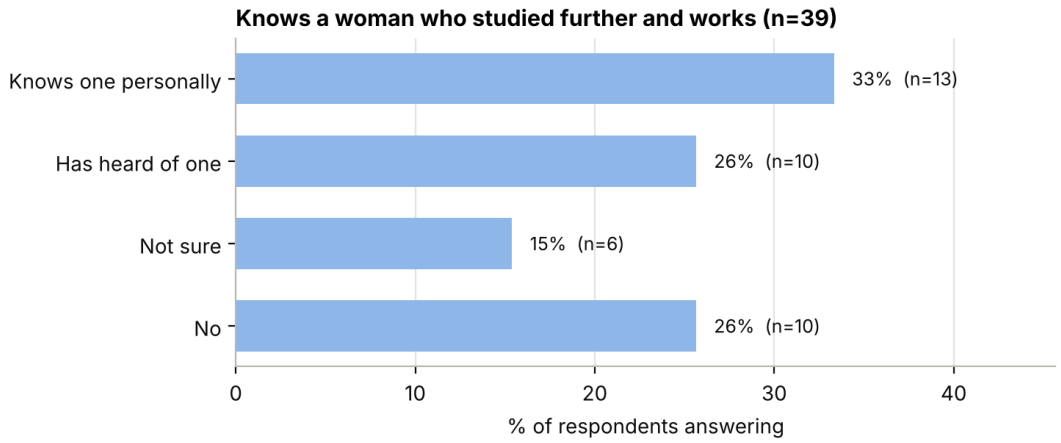


Figure 22. Knows a woman who studied further and works.

8. For girls today

Among the 28 women who answered how far they would like girls in their care to study, 12 (43%) said "as far as she wants", 5 said until she can get a job or profession, and 7 named a specific level such as class 12 or graduation. A few women said they could not afford more, or that girls' education ends at marriage.

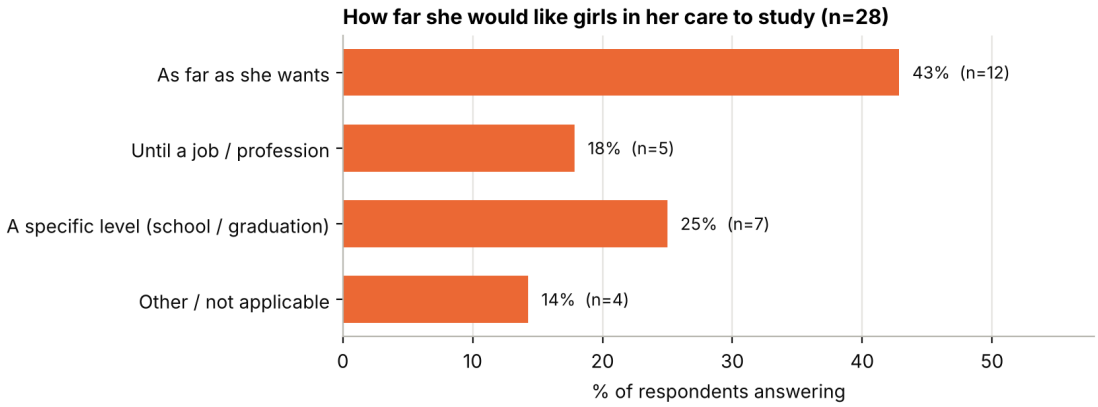


Figure 23. How far she would like girls in her care to study.

What would help girls continue (n=23): fees, books or a scholarship (16), less work at home (9), family support (7), and someone to guide them (5). Two women asked for books and materials in Bengali, two for safe transport, and one said hostel facilities need documents that families could not provide. Five said nothing would make a difference.

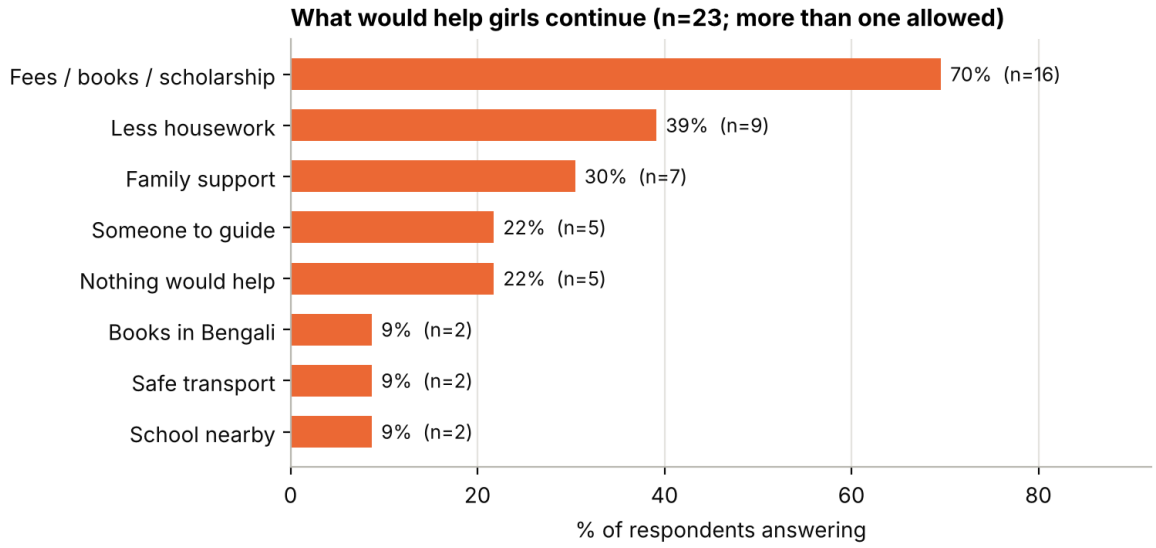


Figure 24. What would help girls continue (more than one allowed). Few women answered this question (23).

9. Patterns and relationships

This section asks which answers tend to go together. The aim is to see what the data point to, not to prove the cause. We measure each relationship with a rank correlation (ρ): 0 means no relationship, +1 or −1 a perfect one, and about ±0.3 a moderate one. Every figure shows how many women are in it. These are exploratory: we looked at many pairs, so a few "significant" results will appear by chance, and small groups (especially anything involving only 25 to 50 women) deserve caution.

9.1 Younger women have studied further

This is the strongest and clearest relationship in the survey. Across 84 women, the younger the woman, the further she studied (ρ = -0.57). The typical (median) woman in her 20s reached class 9.5, in her 30s class 9, in her 40s class 5, in her 50s class 4, and women in their 60s typically never attended. The change is not gradual: the median falls from about class 9 for women in their 30s to about class 5 for women in their 40s. Women who are now around 40 to 45 seem to be the generation after which schooling rose.

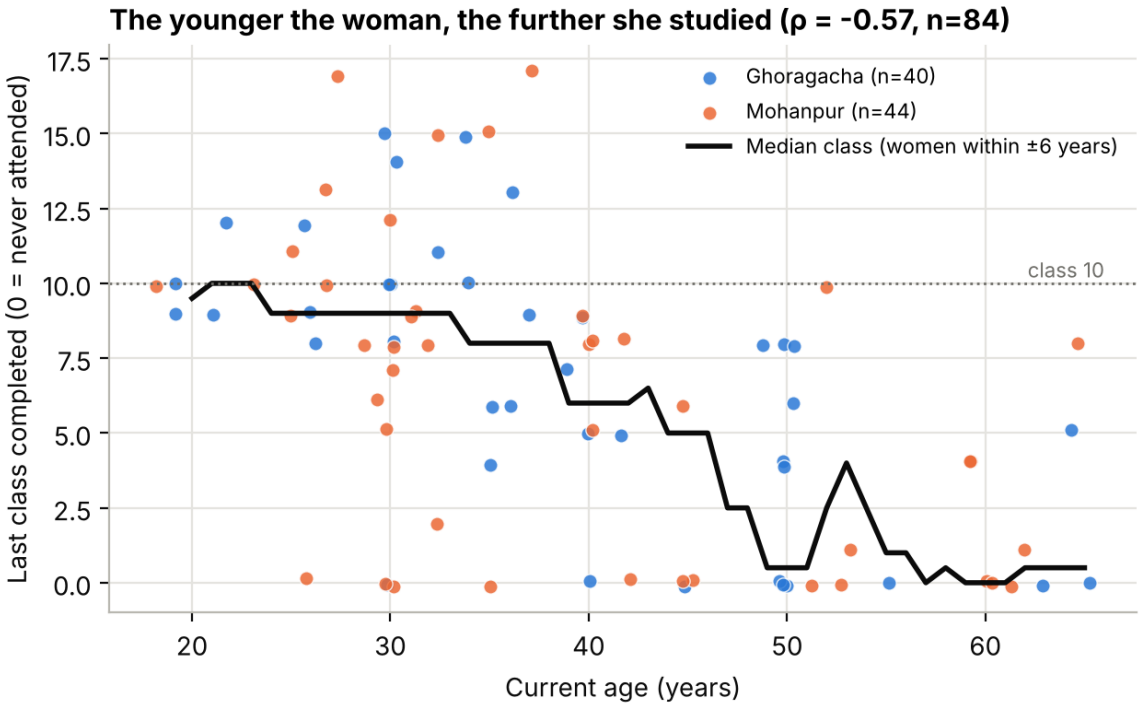


Figure 25. Current age and last class completed. Each dot is one woman; the black line is the running median. The dotted line marks class 10.

9.2 What women want for girls does not depend on their own age

We also asked how far each woman would like girls in her care (daughters, granddaughters) to study. Among the 27 women with a clear answer, 22 wanted girls to go far (a degree, a profession, or "as far as she wants"), 2 named school level (class 10 or 12) and 3 gave a limited answer (until marriage, or not possible because of money). There was no relationship with the woman's own age (ρ = -0.0): young mothers and grandmothers answered alike. Among five women who never attended school themselves, three wanted girls to study far. The few limited answers came from women of 30, 37 and 53.

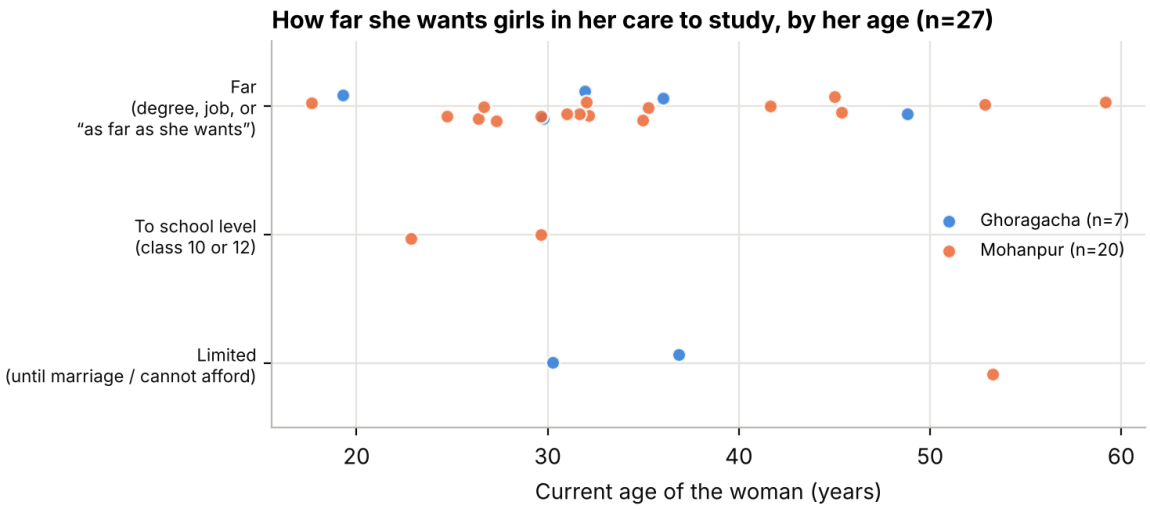


Figure 26. How far she wants girls in her care to study, by her own age. Each dot is one woman, shifted slightly so dots do not overlap.

Her own schooling shows only a weak, uncertain link with this wish (ρ = 0.29, n=27; not distinguishable from chance). The more important message is that **the wish for girls to study is nearly universal among the women who answered, regardless of age, and across levels of own schooling.** The answers to this question come from only 27 women, so the finding should be rechecked in a larger survey.

9.3 Marriage and cost: two different stories

Women who mentioned **marriage** as a reason had typically reached a higher class (median class 9, n=51) than women who did not (median class 0.5, n=34). Women who mentioned **cost or poverty** had typically reached a lower class (median 4.5, n=46) than those who did not (median 9, n=39). Both differences are large and unlikely to be chance ($p < 0.001$, Mann–Whitney test). In plain terms: cost keeps girls out of school or ends it early; marriage ends schooling for girls who had got further.

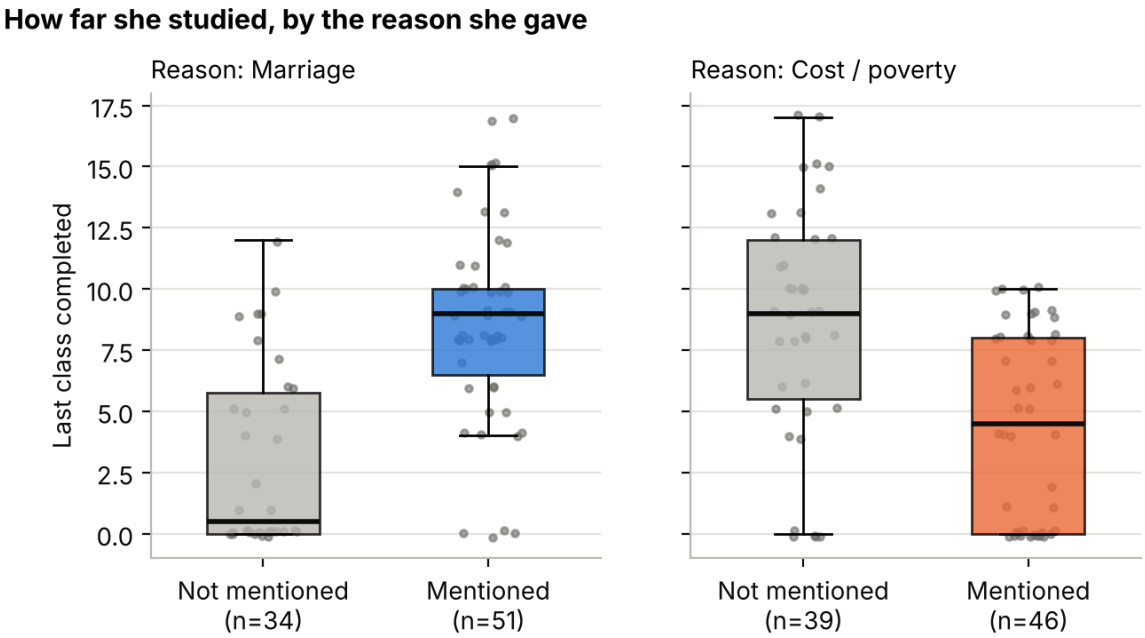


Figure 27. Last class completed, by whether she mentioned marriage (left) or cost (right) as a reason. The box shows the middle half of women; the line is the median.

The reasons shift across generations. Marriage was mentioned by 82% of women under 30 and 71% of those aged 30–39, against 38–47% of women 40 and above (ρ with age = -0.34). Cost shows the opposite pattern: 35–39% under 40 and 62–80% for women 40 and above (ρ = 0.32). Housework and care duties were mentioned by about a third of women in every age group (no clear trend).

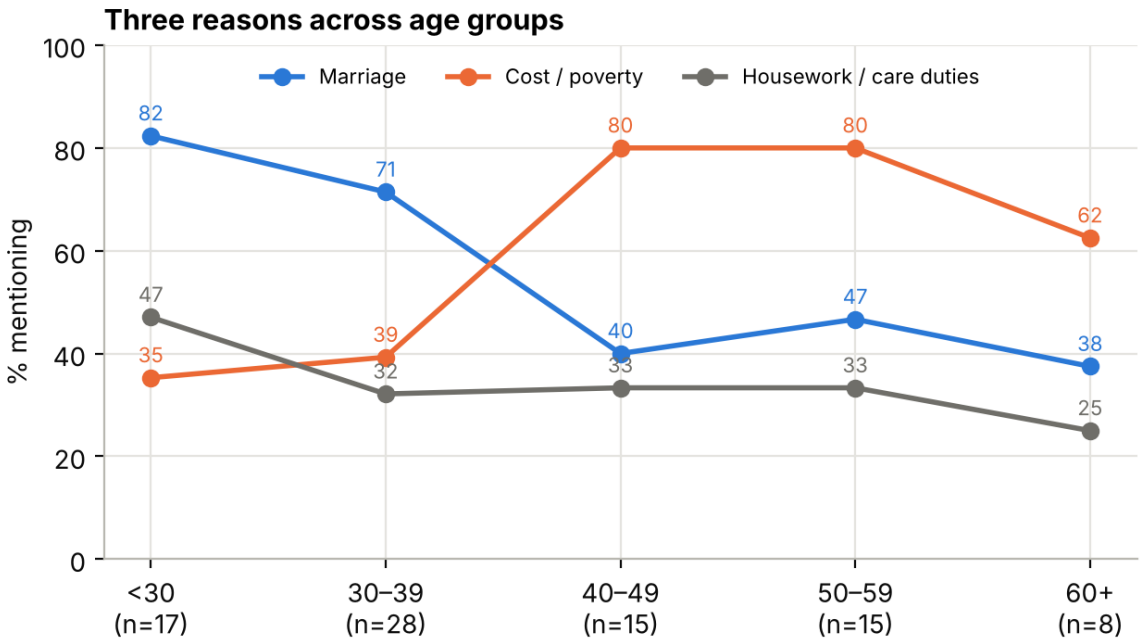


Figure 28. Share of women mentioning marriage, cost, and housework or care duties, by age group.

9.4 Who decided, and what it relates to

Among 55 women who said who decided she would stop, in-laws or husband were named more often by women who had been married or engaged when they stopped (ρ with marriage = 0.43). Women whose in-laws or husband decided were also less interested in learning now: 3 of 12 (25%) said yes or maybe, against 24 of 38 (62%) of the others (Fisher p = 0.04). It is a small group, and the result could be chance, but it fits the idea that the person who once decided can still shape what feels possible. It should be checked in a larger survey.

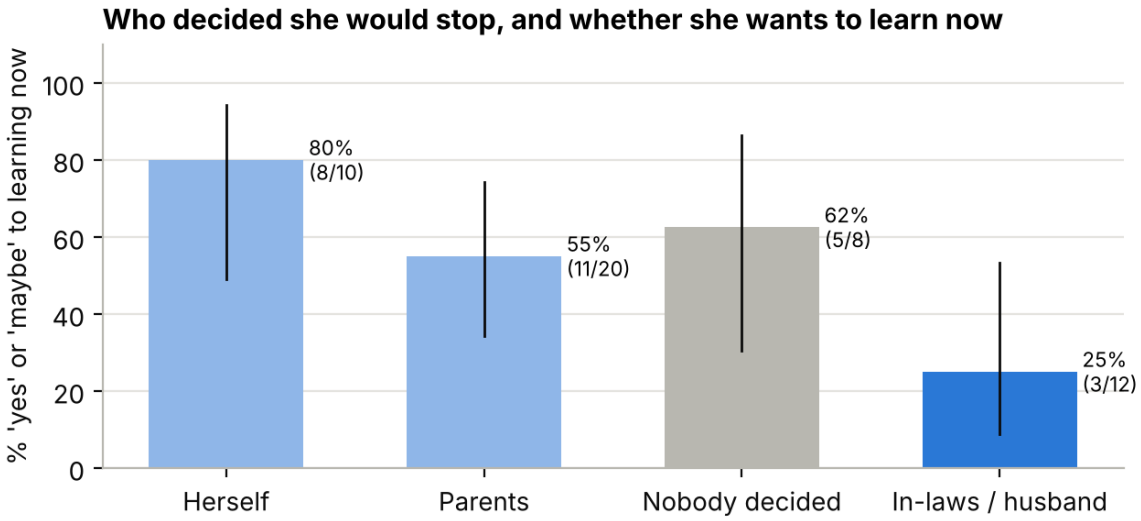


Figure 29. Interest in learning now (yes or maybe), by who decided she would stop. Lines show 95% intervals, which are wide because the groups are small.

9.5 Schooling, reading and phones

The further a woman studied, the more likely she was to read and write (ρ = 0.66, n=50) and to have a phone (ρ = 0.52, n=49). Among women who never attended, 23% said they could read and write; among women who reached class 6 or higher the figure was 100–100%. Own smartphone ownership rose from 17% of women who never attended to 86% among women who reached class 11 or higher. Older women were less likely to read and write (ρ = -0.37) or to have a phone (ρ = -0.32), which mostly reflects the same schooling gap by age.

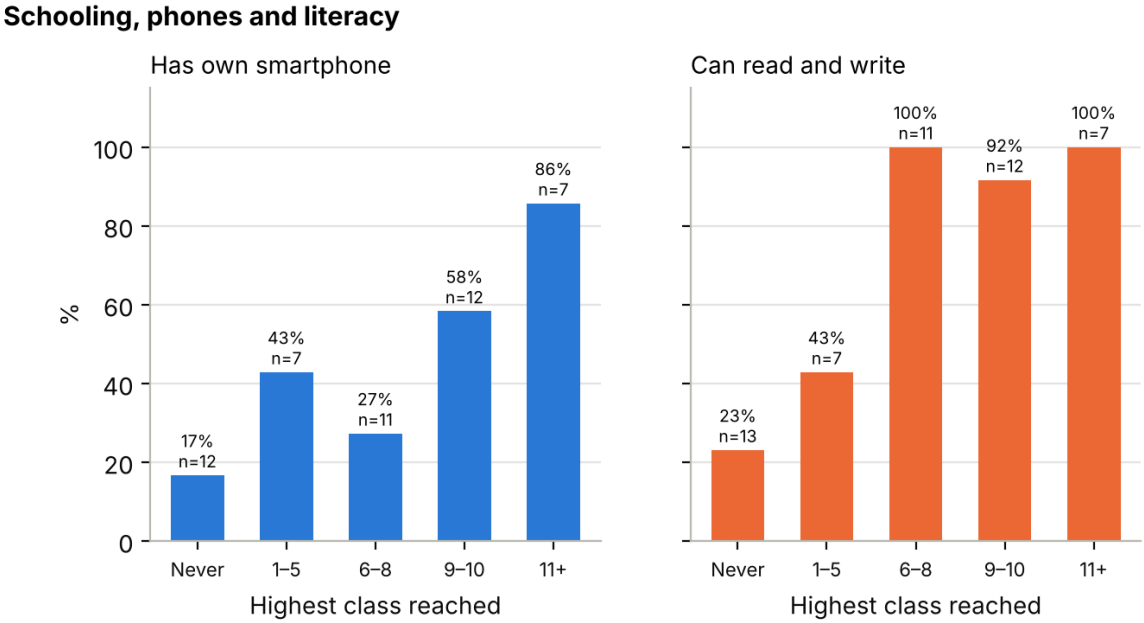


Figure 30. Own smartphone and reading and writing, by highest class reached. Percentages show the women in each group; n is below each bar.

A woman's age showed no relationship with whether she wants to learn now (ρ = 0.00, n=74), so interest in learning is present across generations, including among women who never went to school.

9.6 Reasons that go together

Some reasons tend to be mentioned together. Housework or care duties went with in-laws or husband not allowing (φ = 0.34) and with the family not prioritising girls' schooling (0.32). Marriage went with in-laws or husband (0.31). Cost and marriage were less often mentioned together (–0.28): the two stories above are mostly different women.

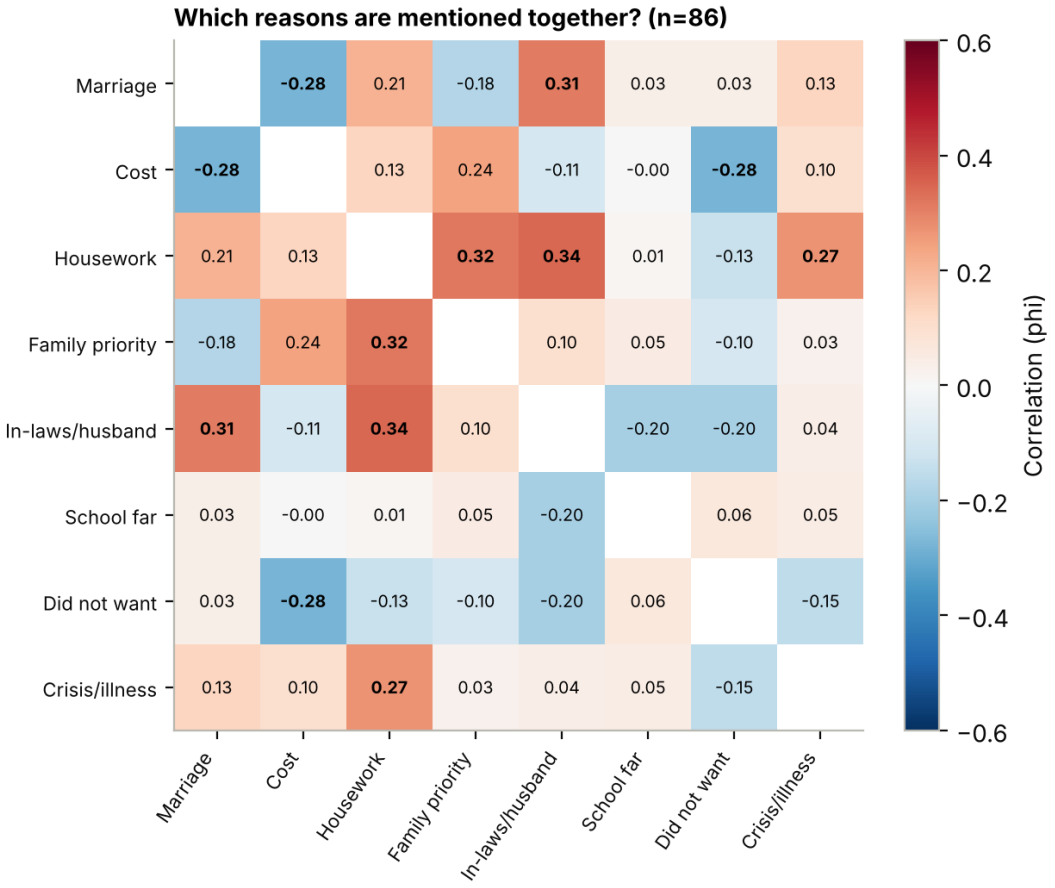


Figure 31. How often reasons are mentioned together (phi correlation, n=86). Bold values are 0.25 or above in size.

9.7 All relationships at a glance

The grid below shows every pair we examined (with at least 15 women having both answers). 78 pairs were examined, and 34 have $p < 0.05$, many more than the roughly 3.9 expected by chance. Many of those are two ways of asking the same thing (for example being married or engaged when she stopped, and naming marriage as a reason), so we do not read them as separate findings. The relationships we consider most solid are age with schooling (strong), age and schooling with marriage and cost as reasons, and schooling with reading and phone use.

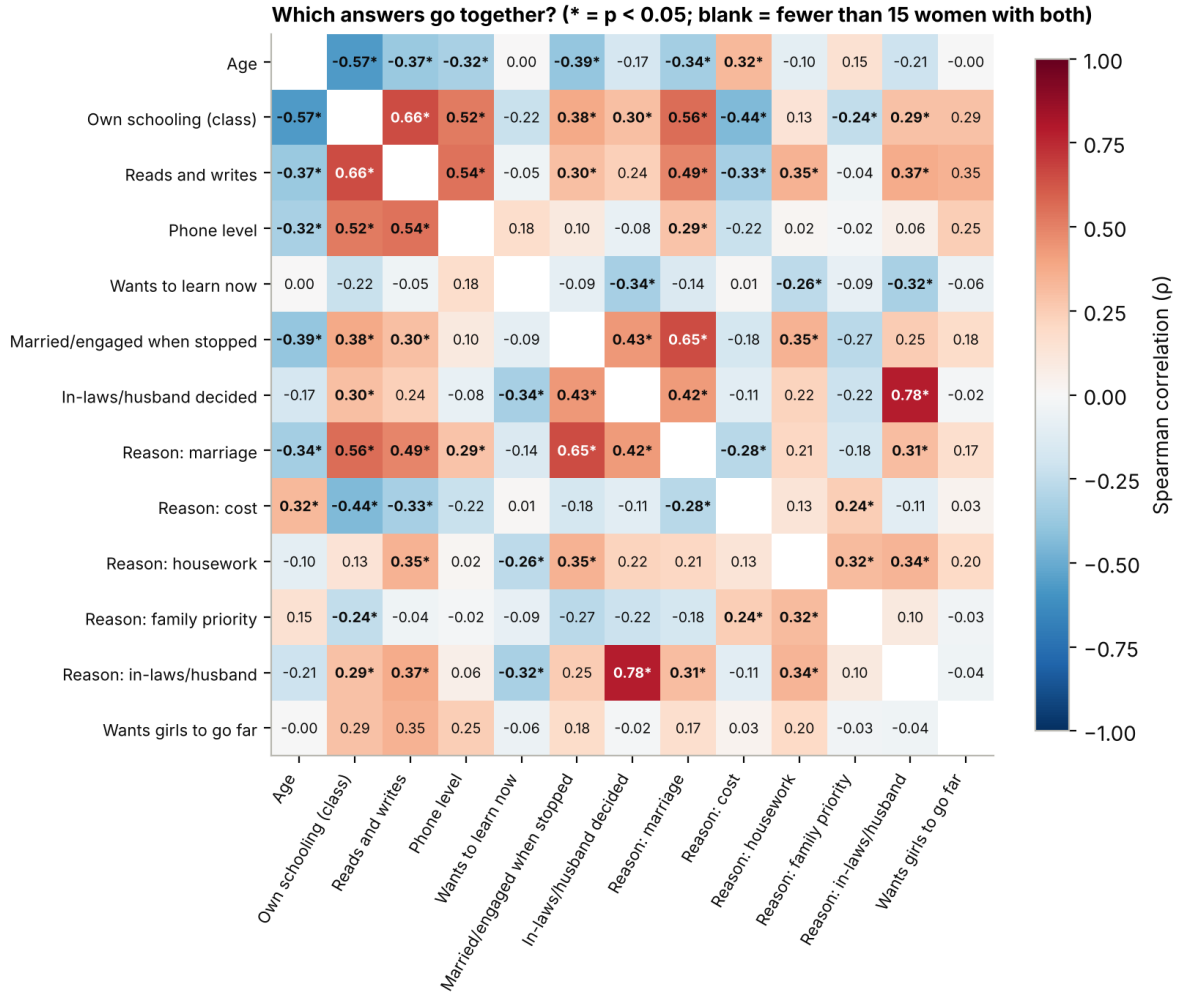


Figure 32. Rank correlations between pairs of answers. Red = go up together; blue = one goes up as the other goes down. * means p < 0.05.

What the data point to:
(1) Schooling for girls has risen quickly in the generation now in their 30s and younger
(2) The obstacles have changed too: cost ended schooling for older women, marriage for younger ones
(3) The wish that girls study far is shared across ages, across levels of own schooling
(4) Interest in learning now exists in every age group, but is lower among women whose in-laws or husband once decided she would stop
(5) Women with less schooling have less reading ability and less phone access, which matters for any learning programme delivered by phone. These are patterns in the women we spoke to, not proof of cause, and several rest on small groups.

10. Comparing Ghoragacha and Mohanpur

We compare the villages on every question where at least some Ghoragacha women have a recorded answer. The important caution is the number of answers on each side: Mohanpur has 44 to 46 women for most questions, Ghoragacha has far fewer for some, because most Ghoragacha entries were recorded as short notes in which these questions were not filled in. Each chart and table below states exactly how many women in each village answered. Women who did not answer are not counted as “no”.

10.1 Schooling and wanting to learn (answered by most women in both villages)

Measure	Ghoragacha	Mohanpur	p-value (Fisher)
Ever attended school	33 of 43 (77%)	34 of 46 (74%)	0.81
Reached class 9 or above	17 of 43 (40%)	15 of 46 (33%)	0.52
Yes or maybe to learning now	16 of 32 (50%)	27 of 45 (60%)	0.49

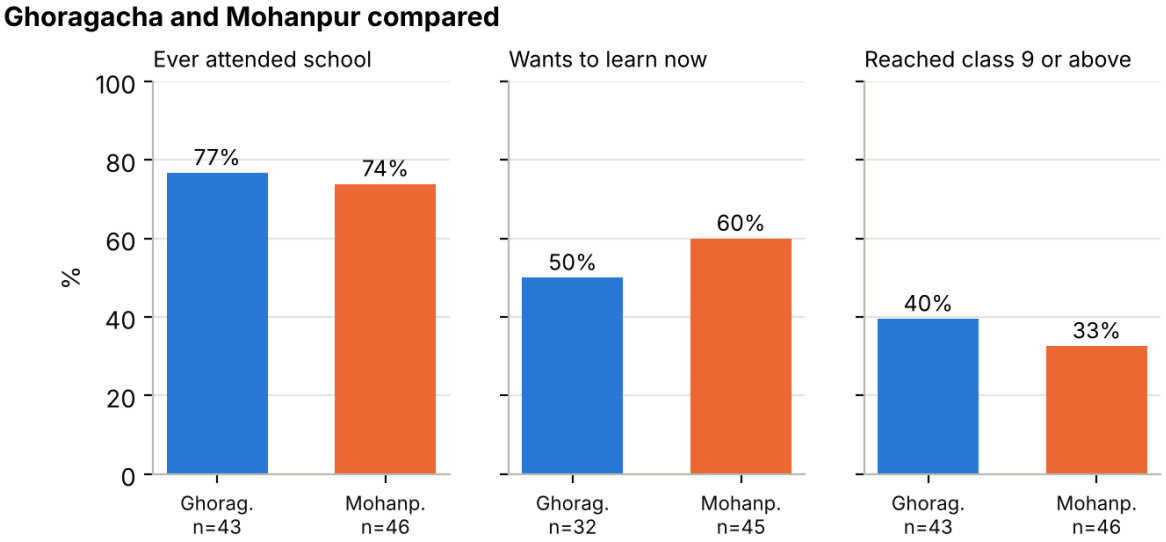


Figure 33. Ghoragacha and Mohanpur compared on three measures answered by most women in both villages.

None of these differences is statistically meaningful (every p-value is above 0.4). We cannot say the villages differ, and we cannot say they are the same; with 32 to 46 women per village, only large differences would show up.

10.2 Reading and writing, work and phone use (fewer Ghoragacha answers)

Reading and writing was recorded for 8 Ghoragacha women and 45 Mohanpur women. In Ghoragacha, 5 of 8 could read and write, 1 read only and 2 neither. In Mohanpur, 30 of 45 (67%) could read and write, 6 read only or sign only, and 9 (20%) neither. The proportion who could read and write is similar, but eight Ghoragacha women is too few to say more.

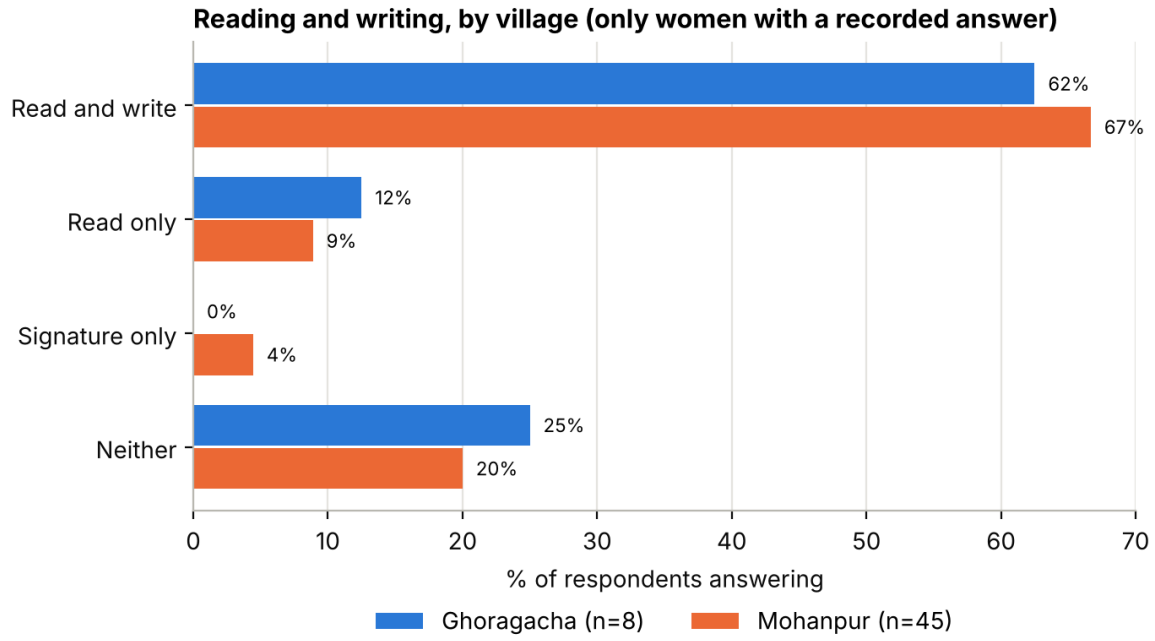


Figure 34. Reading and writing, by village. Only women with a recorded answer are included (Ghoragacha n=8, Mohanpur n=45).

Work was recorded for 11 Ghoragacha women and 44 Mohanpur women. The pattern differs: in Mohanpur 33 of 44 (75%) described their main work as the household, while in Ghoragacha 5 of 11 described farm or family work (for example work in the fields) and 4 household only. Because the Ghoragacha women with a recorded answer may not be typical of the 44, we treat this as a possible difference worth checking, not a finding.

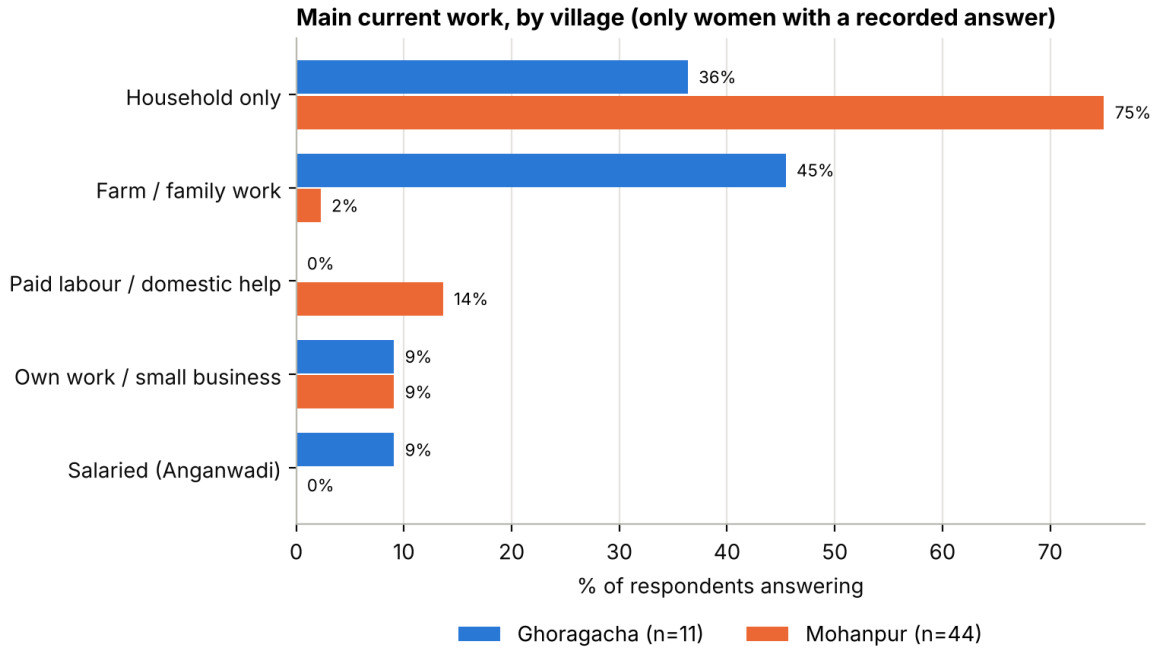


Figure 35. Main current work, by village. Only women with a recorded answer are included (Ghoragacha n=11, Mohanpur n=44).

Phone use was recorded for 6 Ghoragacha women and 45 Mohanpur women. In Ghoragacha, 2 of 6 had their own smartphone, 1 a basic phone and 3 no phone. In Mohanpur, 20 of 45 (44%) had their own

smartphone, 13 a basic phone, 4 shared a phone and 8 (18%) had none. With six Ghoragacha answers, no comparison is possible beyond noting that both villages include women with and without phones.

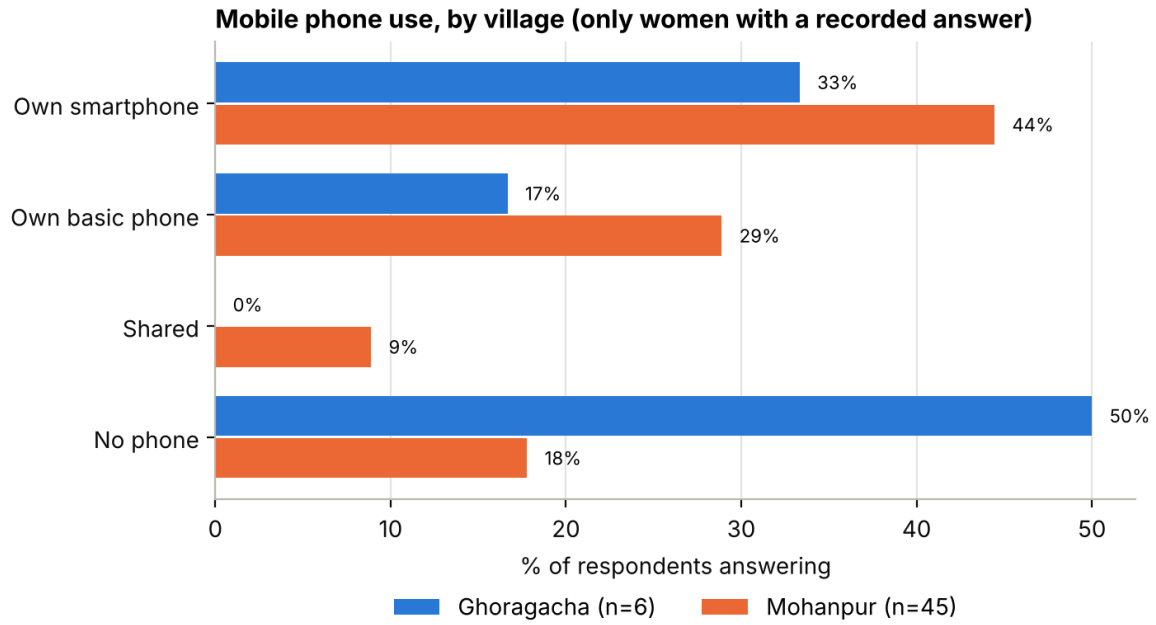


Figure 36. Mobile phone use, by village. Only women with a recorded answer are included (Ghoragacha n=6, Mohanpur n=45).

What the other Ghoragacha entries did not report:
36 of 44 Ghoragacha entries have no reading-and-writing answer, 33 have no work answer, and 38 have no phone answer. The same is true for who decided (31 blank), marriage at the time (37 blank), distance to school (38 blank) and role models (39 blank). These are gaps in the records, not "no" answers. The comparisons above use only the women who consented to answer the questions asked without hesitation.

10.3 Reasons, by village

Reasons for stopping or never starting were recorded for 41 of 44 Ghoragacha women and 45 of 46 Mohanpur women.

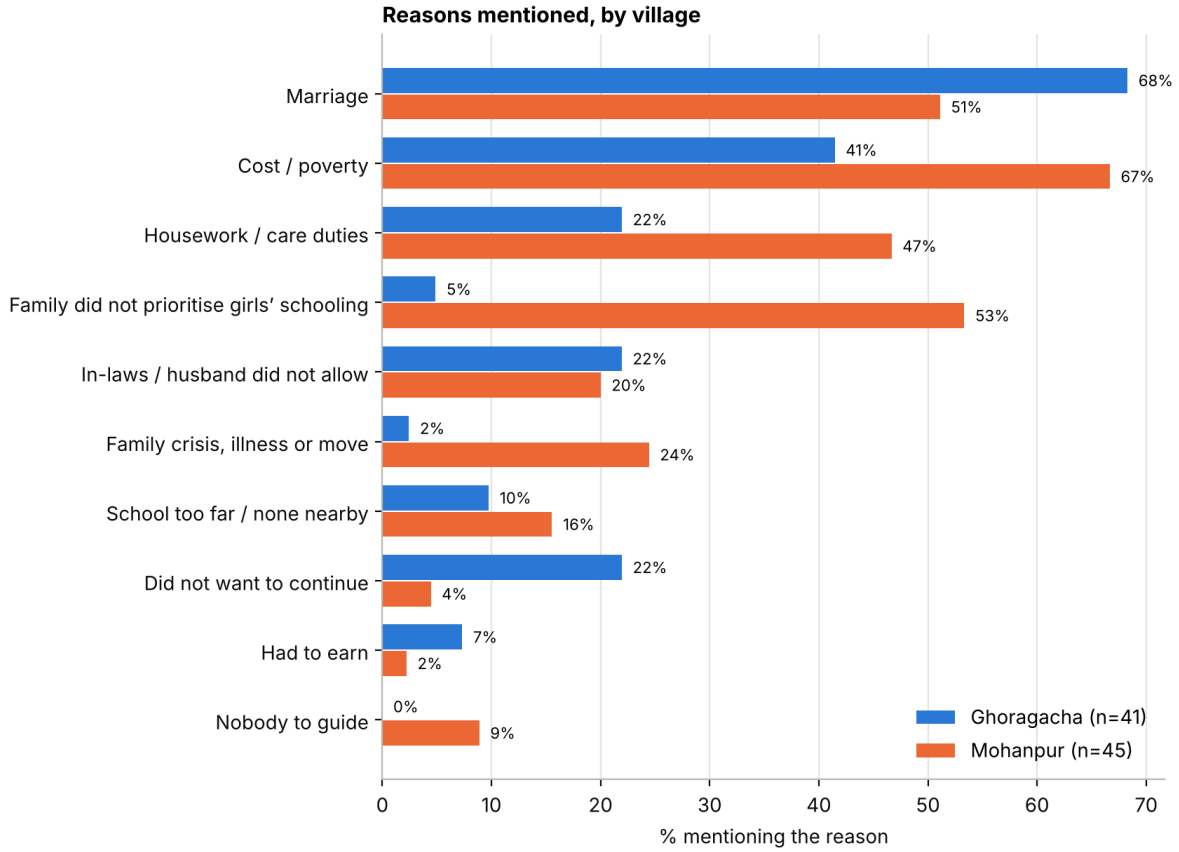


Figure 37. Reasons mentioned, by village (more than one allowed). Ghoragacha n=41, Mohanpur n=45.

Marriage was mentioned by 68% of Ghoragacha women and 51% of Mohanpur women; cost or poverty by 41% and 67%; in-laws or husband not allowing by 22% and 20%. Marriage was the most-mentioned reason in Ghoragacha and cost in Mohanpur.

11. How reliable are these numbers?

11.1 Completeness

Two entry styles were used. 52 entries (mostly Mohanpur) are full questionnaires, with 75 to 100% of the core questions answered. 38 entries (nearly all Ghoragacha) are short notes: schooling and age were recorded for almost all, but literacy, work, who decided, marriage, distance and phone were rarely recorded. This is primarily due to the hesitancy shown by some women. It might partly be because many of the interviews in Ghoraghacha had family members present nearby. Some incompleteness is also due to the loss in data due to the short entries taken at Ghoraghacha.

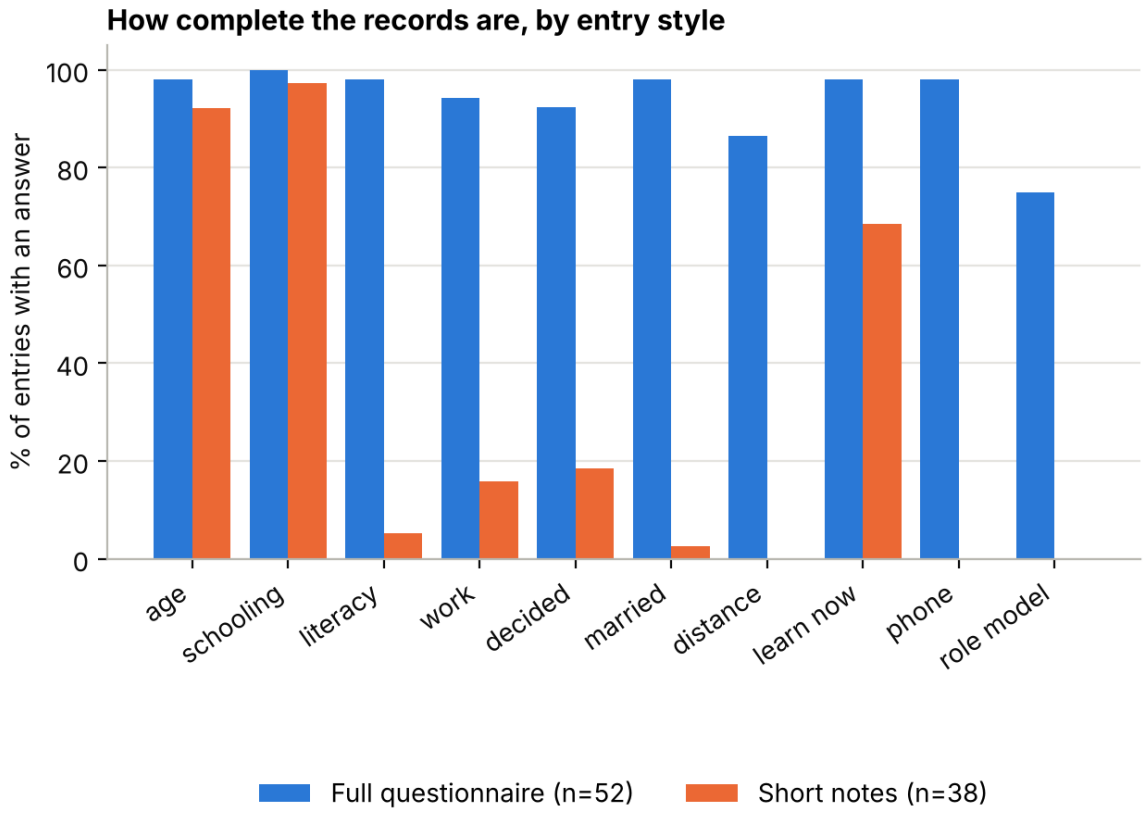


Figure 38. Share of entries with an answer for each core question, by entry style.

This is the main reason that sample sizes shrink from 90 to about 50 for many questions. It is a limitation of the women's answers as well as of the data collection, and we recommend that any follow-up surveys take note of this.

After realising that the data collection method that we used at Ghoraghacha was not efficient, we changed the survey method for Mohanpur. This significantly changed the quality of the reported data for the better. We recommend that any follow-up surveys keep this in mind.

11.2 Interview setting

Who else was present was recorded for 50 women. 18 (36%) were interviewed alone, 21 (42%) with other women present, 7 (14%) with a man present, and 4 with children only or a mixed group. Women may answer differently when family members, especially men, are listening, for example about in-laws' decisions. We did not find enough cases to test this.

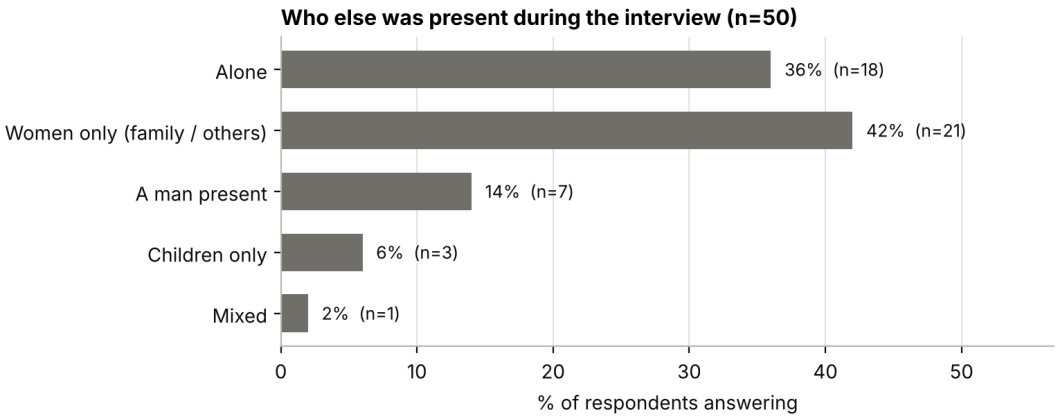


Figure 39. Who else was present during the interview

12. Limits of this survey

- **Not a random sample.** We spoke with women who were available and willing. Women who were not at home (for example at work or in the fields), or who declined, may differ in important ways. 12 women declined; we do not know their reasons.
- **Two sites, small numbers.** 90 women in two places cannot represent a district, a state, or all villages. Percentages from small groups (for example by age band) can move a lot with a few women.
- **Reasons are accounts, not causes.** Several reasons usually act together (for example, cost and marriage). A reason mentioned is what the woman told us, as an interviewer understood it.
- **Memory.** Older women described events decades ago.
- **Coding.** Our team grouped answers into categories. Though we have tried our best to reduce inconsistencies, another team might group some answers differently. The raw categories and rules are in Appendix B. After the first survey at Ghoraghacha, we changed our data collection method. This significantly improved the survey efficiency.
- **Only women were asked.** We did not hear from men, adolescents, teachers or the girls themselves.
- **Sensitive topics.** Questions about in-laws, marriage and money may lead some women to under-report. Nothing here should be used to judge any family or any individual.

13. What this suggests

The points below are suggestions from our team, offered for discussion with the organisations who know these villages. They are not conclusions the data can prove.

For local NGOs and Ek Pehal

1. Family support was the single most-named missing factor (38 of 51 women). Outreach to parents, in-laws and husbands, such as meetings or home visits, may matter as much as classes for girls.
2. Many younger women reached class 9 or higher and then stopped at marriage. Early conversations with families about continuing education after marriage, and with prospective in-laws, could be explored.

3. More than half of the women who answered (43 of 77) were interested in learning now, most often a skill such as sewing or computers, but time was the main barrier (25 of 47). Short sessions at times that fit housework, close to home, may suit better than fixed classes.
4. Confidence and age were barriers for 12 and 9 of 47 women. Peer groups of women learning together, and meeting women who studied further (a third of the women who answered knew one personally), may help.
5. Smartphone use was common among younger women and less common above 50, so phone-based learning will reach some women and not others. Materials in Bengali were asked for.

For the administration and the local village government

- **Support the costs that families cite.** Fees, books and scholarships were named as helping by 29 of 51 women for themselves and by 16 of 23 for girls today. Where outreach can link families to existing scholarships or documents (one woman mentioned documents for hostel admission), that could help.
- **Continue community outreach that includes families.** Outreach already run with Ek Pehal and in schools could add sessions for parents and in-laws.

Questions that we couldn't answer

- How common are these patterns among women who were not home when we visited?
- Do girls in these villages today face the same obstacles, or different ones? (Only 28 women answered about girls in their care.)
- What would men and in-laws say would change their decisions?
- How have girls' school completion rates changed in recent years? Records from local schools could answer this better than a survey.

Acknowledgements

We give our sincere thanks to every woman who gave her time, to the student interviewers (Dixita Adhikari, Jessica Das, Shibraj Sahu, Chayanika Mandal, Pradumnya Pal, Divyanshu Saha, Arunabha Dutta, Ruben Pulickal and Naren Pathania), , to Ek Pehal, and to Dr. Malancha Ta and Dr. Rumi De for their valuable feedback and guidance.

Appendix A. Data tables

All counts are for the 90 adult women in the analysis. "n" is the number who answered that question.

A1. Village

A2. Age group

Category	Women	% of n=90
Mohanpur	46	51%
Ghoragacha	44	49%

A3. Highest schooling level

Category	Women	% of n=86
<30	17	20%
30–39	29	34%
40–49	16	19%
50–59	16	19%
60+	8	9%

A4. Reading and writing

Category	Women	% of n=89
Never attended	22	25%
Primary (1–5)	14	16%
Upper primary (6–8)	19	21%
Secondary (9–10)	18	20%
Higher secondary (11–12)	5	6%
College	9	10%
Class not recorded	2	2%

A5. Main current work

Category	Women	% of n=53
Read and write	35	66%
Read only	5	9%
Signature only	2	4%
Neither	11	21%

A6. Who decided she would stop

Category	Women	% of n=55
Household only	37	67%
Paid labour / domestic help	6	11%
Farm / family work	6	11%
Own work / small business	5	9%
Salaried (Anganwadi)	1	2%

A7. Married or engaged when she stopped

Category	Women	% of n=55
Parents	21	38%
In-laws / husband	16	29%
Herself	10	18%
Nobody decided	8	15%

A8. Distance to school

Category	Women	% of n=52
Yes	27	52%
No	25	48%

A9. Study or learn now?

Category	Women	% of n=45
1–3 km	17	38%
Under 1 km	10	22%
Over 3 km	7	16%
Cycle / vehicle	6	13%
No school nearby	5	11%

A10. Mobile phone

Category	Women	% of n=77
Yes	30	39%
Maybe	13	17%
No	34	44%

A11. Knows a woman who studied further and works

Category	Women	% of n=51
Own smartphone	22	43%
Own basic phone	14	27%
No phone	11	22%
Shared	4	8%

A12. Who else was present

Category	Women	% of n=39
Knows one personally	13	33%
No	10	26%
Has heard of one	10	26%
Not sure	6	15%

A13. Highest schooling level, by village

Category	Women	% of n=50
Women only (family / others)	21	42%
Alone	18	36%
A man present	7	14%
Children only	3	6%
Mixed	1	2%

A14. Reasons mentioned, by age group (women mentioning / women in group)

Level	Ghoragacha	Mohanpur
Never attended	10	12
Primary (1–5)	7	7
Upper primary (6–8)	9	10
Secondary (9–10)	10	8
Higher secondary (11–12)	3	2
College	4	5
Class not recorded	0	2

Reason	<30	30–39	40–49	50–59	60+
Marriage	14/17	20/28	6/15	7/15	3/8
Cost / poverty	6/17	11/28	12/15	12/15	5/8
Housework / care duties	8/17	9/28	5/15	5/15	2/8
Family did not prioritise girls' schooling	4/17	7/28	5/15	7/15	3/8
In-laws / husband did not allow	6/17	7/28	3/15	1/15	1/8
Family crisis, illness or move	3/17	4/28	0/15	2/15	3/8

Appendix B. How answers were grouped (codebook)

- **Village.** From the form.
- **Age.** The number given. One entry ("35 approx") was read as 35. One respondent aged 17 was excluded.
- **Schooling level.** From the last class reported. Numerals and Roman numerals were read as classes; BA, graduation and bachelor's were "College"; "college 2nd year" was class 13; "XII with vocational course" was class 12. Women who said they had never attended school are "Never attended".
- **Reading and writing.** "Both", "read and write" and "somewhat" were grouped as Read and write.

- **Work.** Grouped as household only; farm or family work; paid labour or domestic help; own work or small business (sewing, tea shop, shop); salaried (Anganwadi).
- **Reasons.** Reasons were taken from the woman's own words as recorded by the interviewer. They were grouped into 12 categories. "Marriage" includes marriage, engagement or marriage taking priority. "Cost / poverty" includes fees, poverty, lack of money or debt for schooling. "Family did not prioritise girls' schooling" includes a family view that girls do not need much education, boys being prioritised, and parents not allowing or encouraging. "In-laws / husband did not allow" is only counted where in-laws or husband were said to have stopped or not agreed. "Housework / care duties" includes housework, looking after siblings and caring for a baby. "Family crisis, illness or move" includes a death, a parent's illness, and family moves.
- **Who decided.** Myself; parents; in-laws or husband (grouped); nobody decided.
- **Missing answers.** A blank is treated as not answered, never as "no".

Appendix C. In women's words (paraphrased from interviewer notes)

These short lines are taken from interviewers' notes or recorded answers, lightly edited. They are not exact quotations. Details that could identify a person or household have been removed.

- "She didn't want to leave her studies, but family pressure forced her. She wants her daughter to learn to be independent."
- "There was no awareness about education when she was growing up."
- "Sons were given priority and told to teach her; she never got the chance to go to school."
- "Parents didn't allow her to study; the school was far away."
- "She wanted to study but couldn't. She was married."
- "Marriage and a baby: can't study now, with family and health."
- "Someone came to start literacy classes, but he soon left. After that, nothing."
- "Would continue if she gets better family help and time."
- "Hostel facilities need documents that the family could not provide."
- "In our family, the daughters are good students."

Appendix D. Consent, privacy and ethics

Interviewers introduced themselves as IISER Kolkata students, explained why we were asking, and asked for spoken consent, which was recorded on the form. The student volunteers explicitly mentioned that the participation was voluntary and that no responses would be tracked back to them. The participants were also informed that they had the freedom to skip questions or stop, and that names would not be recorded. Each woman has a serial number and age only. No names, addresses, phone numbers, voice recordings or photographs were collected. Small groups and individual details are not reported in ways that could identify a person, and details that could identify a household have been left out.